



RAIDING THE OBSIDIAN KEEP

Swing swords and face strange sorceries!

An OSE adventure for level 2-4, playable in several sessions
and likely to lead adventurers to death or glory.

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Find other fine adventures by **Joseph R. Lewis**
and the **Dungeon Age** collection on drivethrurpg.com

A lot of them are in Bryce Lynch's The Best category,
a guarantee of quality if ever there was one!

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WELCOME!

Welcome to a sword & sorcery adventure by Joseph R. Lewis.
This is an expanded, beautified version of *The Obsidian Keep*,
originally published about four years ago.

We Mushmen were impressed with the amount of hazardous adventure
and dreadful doom packed in the original version and asked Joe about
making this version. We talked about what could be added and lent our
humble skills to make this booklet a fun sandbox for low level characters
to bravely explore.

NEW TO THE OSR?

Favored by gamers who sharpened their blades in the dungeons of the twentieth
century and younger RPG fans alike, games and adventures from the Old School

Renaissance movement work somewhat differently from newer fantasy
tabletop RPGs. These adventure games (as we prefer to call them) tend to feature:

Decision making as the core player experience:

solutions are in the world and not on the character sheet.

Open, dynamic environments leading to interesting situa-
tions (and no scripted stories).

The DM as a neutral interface between the world and the
players. (This is why we call them **the referee** instead!)

Referee rulings over detailed rules for every single edge case.

Dice as oracles and generators of unexpected situations,
using tools such as random tables.

No “game balance” so the world is believable and dangerous.

Quick character creation: beginning PCs are fragile but
easily replaced.

We advise you to be upfront with your players about the game style. It may take
some getting used to, especially if they only have experience with more heroic
roleplaying games. You can learn more about how to run (and play in)
adventure / old-school games by reading the following (free!) resources:

» [Principia Apocrypha](https://lithyscaphe.blogspot.com/p/principia-apocrypha.html)*

» [Matt Finch's Primer](https://archive.org/details/a-quick-primer-for-old-school-gaming/A%20Quick%20Primer%20for%20Old%20School%20Gaming/)*

* <https://lithyscaphe.blogspot.com/p/principia-apocrypha.html> - <https://archive.org/details/a-quick-primer-for-old-school-gaming/A%20Quick%20Primer%20for%20Old%20School%20Gaming/>





BACKGROUND

In the subterranean shores of the **Sakeen Sea** stands the holy city of **Radiant Vitela**. In the center of the sea lies **Isla Requia**, where the lords of the **Obsidian Keep** harass passing ships with their magics. In the palace, **Duchess Forza** studied and mastered sorcery. Her husband **Duke Avito** grew jealous of her power.

One year ago, the **Archbishop** of Radiant Vitela secretly sent the red priests of **Vermesh** to seduce and corrupt Duke Avito.

Two weeks ago, the Archbishop sent a fleet of holy warships to destroy the evil Obsidian Keep. The fleet never returned. No one knows what happened to it.

So what happened? For the last year, the red priests have been driving Duke Avito insane and causing everyone in the Obsidian Keep to develop bizarre Chaos

mutations. When the fleet attacked, Duchess Forza used her sorcery to battle the invaders. But Duke Avito wanted the glory of victory, so he sacrificed his youngest daughter Bianca to summon the immortal horror Vermesh into this plane of existence. This eldritch summoning caused a red storm of Chaos, destroying the fleet and damaging the Obsidian Keep.

Today

The shattered remains of the Radiant fleet lie in the harbor. The survivors flee on rafts or huddle in shelters on the beach. Inside the Obsidian Keep, the palace is a nightmare. Only a few people remain alive, all horribly mutated, and some possessing unholy powers. Duchess Forza lies (mostly) dead in the keep. Duke Avito lies (entirely) dead in his private sanctum. But he is not alone.

Meanwhile, the people of Radiant Vitela wonder what happened to their holy fleet...

Learn more about the principal characters and locations, Vermesh and the red priests of Vermesh in **Appendix 1** on [page 68](#). It also contains some tips to adapt these names to your game world.

Your setting: If you wish to incorporate this adventure into your ongoing campaign, you can simply substitute your own port city for Radiant Vitela, your own sea for the Sakeen Sea, and your own ambitious religious leader for the Archbishop. Then place Isla Requia (along with the Obsidian Keep) anywhere off the coast near your port city.



RUNNING THE ADVENTURE

Reading this adventure

Descriptions of locations focus only on key adventure items. You may assume that any “missing” details are obvious, such as cooking pans in a kitchen.

Items that are further explained in their own bullet point or section are **bolded and underlined**.

The Referee’s read-aloud text looks like this.

A few things to know

- This adventure emphasizes exploration, mystery-solving, and social encounters, but also has opportunities for combat (always a risky option).
- Each area (Harbor, Beach, Grounds, Keep) is self-contained. You only need to deal with one at a time.
- Each area starts with a section that provides a quick overview of the location, encounters, NPCs, and what they know.
- There is lots of treasure* (money, jewelry, potions, weapons, armor, artifacts) but also a fair chance of death. You’ve been warned!

* All in all, the equivalent of 75883 gp! But a good part is hard to get, hard to transport or hard to sell.

So many NPCs!

You definitely don’t need to make them all memorable. Each one only shows up for a few minutes, usually. But there are notes for almost every NPC to help you roleplay them, if you want. Also, **Appendix 1** (p. 68) will help you understand things more clearly if needed.

Hooks & rumors

Choose a hook in the sidebar below. Then have each player roll for a rumor on the table opposite.

Starting

The party is dropped off at Isla Requia, where they can explore the wrecked ships in the harbor, meet the survivors on the beach, and make their way to the ruins of the Obsidian Keep (***The arrival***, p. 10).

Death happens

Foolhardy or reckless characters will easily find a dramatic ending. Replacement characters (as well as useful henchmen) can be found on the beach (***Roaring Fire***, p.24). A prisoner in the cells of the Obsidian Keep (***Cell 1-9***, p. 41) may also do the trick.

Hooks

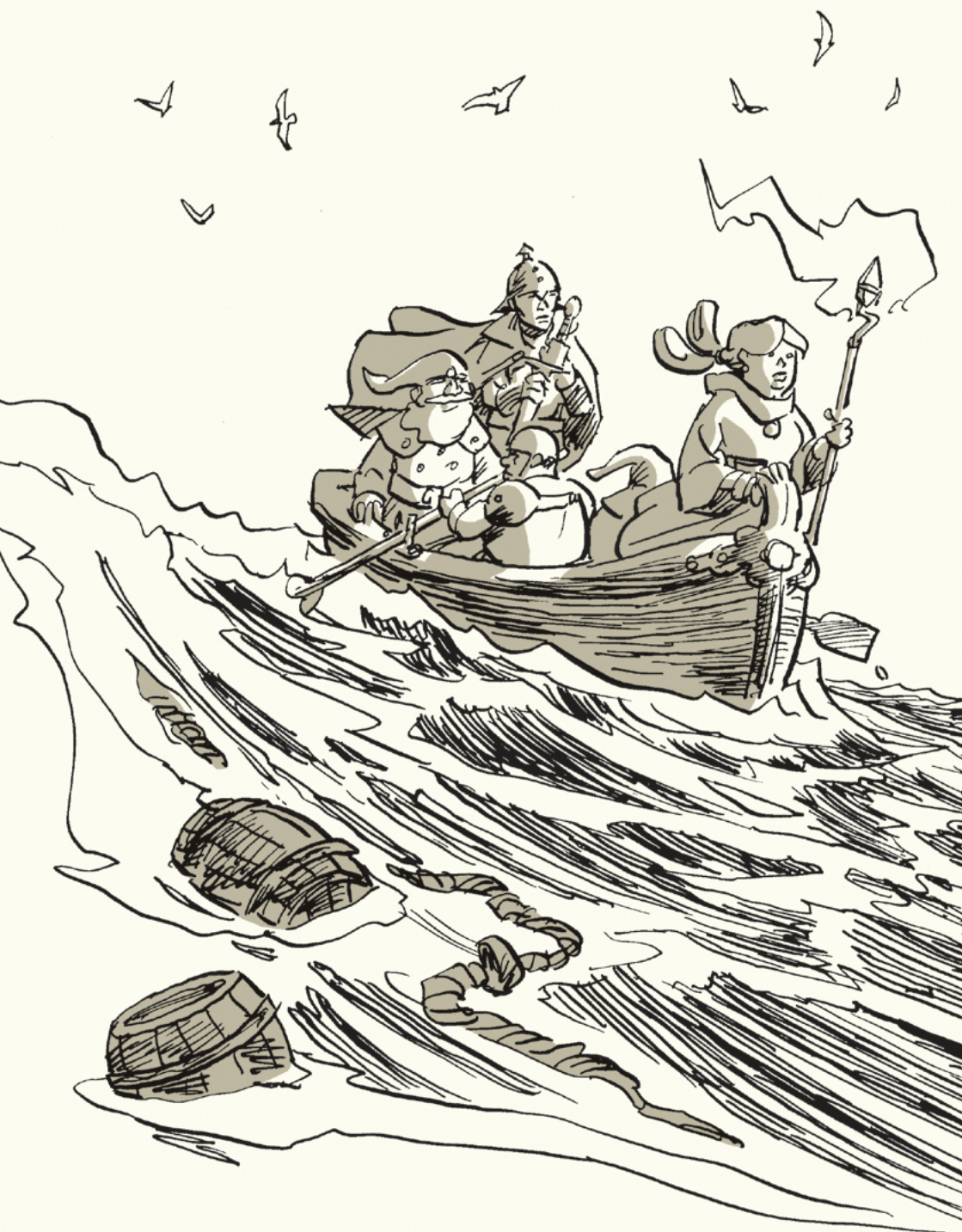
1. The Archbishop of Radiant Vitela has put out a call for any available adventurers to sail to Isla Requia and learn the fate of their lost fleet and of the vile sorcerers. Rewards are offered for saving sailors (50 GP each), recovering relics (500 GP each), and bringing proof that Duke Avito and Duchess Forza are dead (5,000 GP each). *This option may be best suited for a Lawful party.*

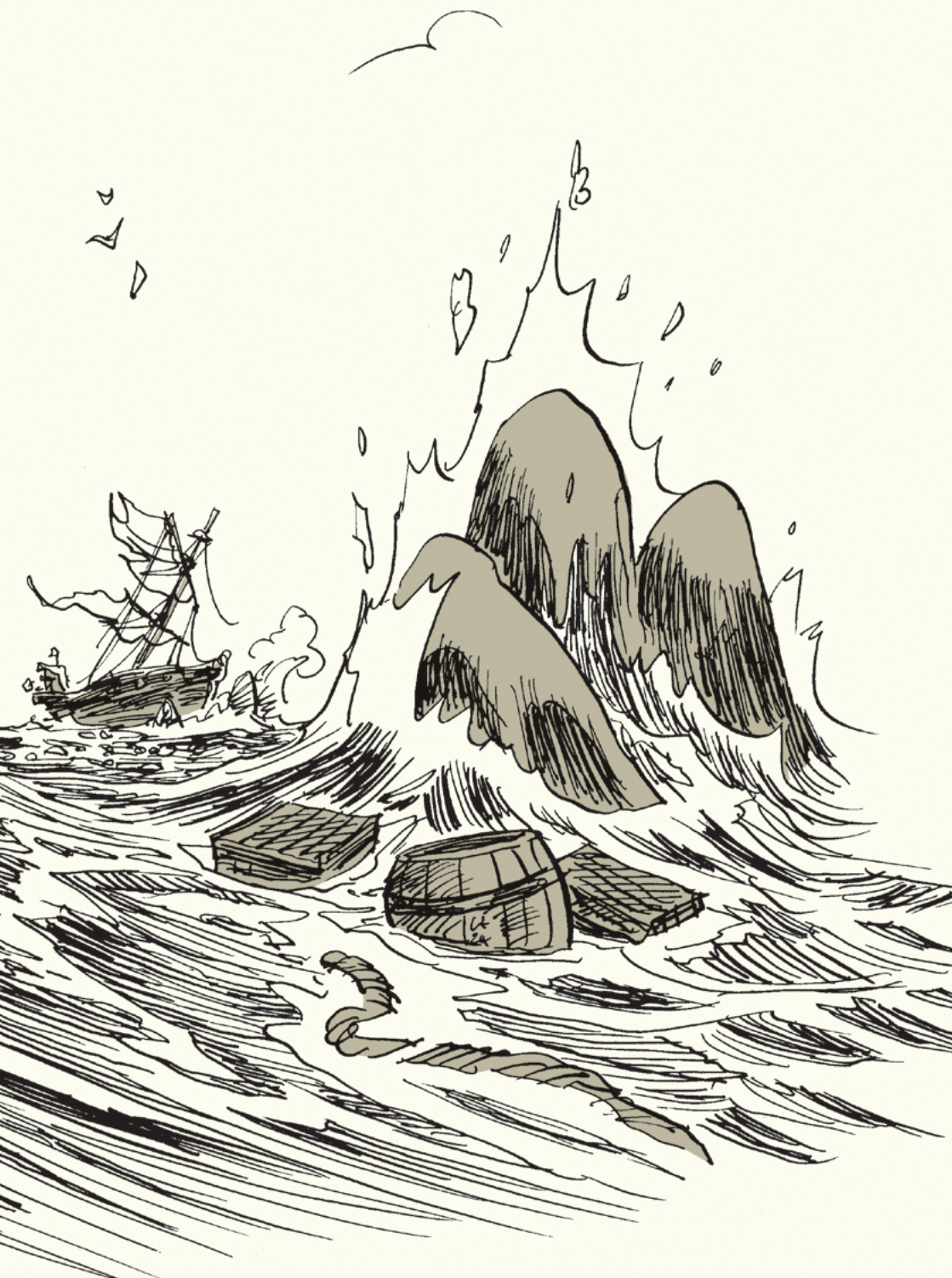
2. The antiques dealer Master Argento of Radiant Vitela is looking for treasure hunters to sail to Isla Requia and recover valuable items. Rewards are offered for eye witnesses (25 GP each), weapons (250 GP each), and Obsidian Keep rarities (1,000 GP each), especially if they belonged to Duke Avito and Duchess Forza (5,000 GP each). *This option may be best suited for a Chaotic party.*

RUMORS

Some rumors are false (F), some are true (T). Roll 1d20 + CHA modifier.
If the result is more than 20, roll again twice with no modifier.

- 1 [F] Isla Requia is fabulously wealthy, populated entirely by sorcerer-kings and their demonic servants.
- 2 [F] Duke Avito is a fey lord in disguise who commands nature itself to do his capricious bidding.
- 3 [F] The Obsidian Keep was built in a single night by an army of demons in return for a thousand souls.
- 4 [F] Duchess Forza made a pact with a Lord of Hell to gain mastery over the minds of men.
- 5 [F] The red priests are agents of a blind Red Dragon, who will soon burn the island to cinders.
- 6 [F] In the harbor of Isla Requia, there is a hideous fish-woman who eats human babies.
- 7 [F] Vermesh was a vampire lord who dabbled in alchemical transformations of living victims.
- 8 [F] The soldiers of the Obsidian Keep have a secret store of celestial armor that cannot be pierced.
- 9 [F] Duke Avito created the cult of the red priests to help him acquire arcane power.
- 10 [F] There is a secret entrance to the Keep's lower levels hidden somewhere on the beach.
- 11 [T] Isla Requia is home to a cabal of decadent aristocrats, and their soldiers, servants, and serfs.
- 12 [T] Duke Avito is a merchant prince who is terribly jealous of his wife's arcane powers.
- 13 [T] Duchess Forza is a brilliant magician who gained her powers through years of hard work and study.
- 14 [T] The Obsidian Keep was built by a mad magician-engineer to house the children he never had.
- 15 [T] The red priests are agents of an eldritch horror, which will soon consume all living things that dream.
- 16 [T] Vermesh was a giant red worm that was banished from this world by a band of heroes long ago.
- 17 [T] In the harbor of Isla Requia, there is a beautiful octopus-woman who eats human fingers.
- 18 [T] The soldiers of the Obsidian Keep have a secret store of cold black otherworldly weapons.
- 19 [T] Duke Avito was seduced by the cult of the red priests, who have their own secret agenda.
- 20 [T] There is a secret entrance to the Keep's lower levels hidden to the west of the Keep Grounds.





THE HARBOR OF DEATH

Where is this place?

The harbor of Isla Requia lies between the Sakeen Sea and the beach below the Obsidian Keep. This is the only safe harbor to approach; the rest of the island is surrounded by rocky shoals and sheer cliffs, which are often buffeted by crashing waves and roaring winds. The island itself is a mere two leagues long and one league wide. The rugged landscape supports olive trees, thorny scrub, sheep, goats, and little else.

What is here?

Shipwrecks, rafts, islands, treasures, and monsters.

Who is here?

A few local fishermen and stranded sailors.

What do they know?

They **all** know the Radiant fleet came to attack the Obsidian Keep, but the fleet was destroyed by a strange “red storm” of lightning.

They **all** strongly suspect the red storm was created by Duchess Forza (lady of the Obsidian Keep) using her evil sorcery.

Sailors want to be rescued. They all refuse to go ashore, out of fear of the palace sorcerers.

Fishermen also know that during the red storm, lava destroyed part of the Obsidian Keep and the fishermen’s cottages above the beach. This is why many fishermen have left, or are trying to leave, the island.

Point-Crawling the Bay

Rowing a small boat from one location to an adjacent location (about 100 yards) takes one turn. Swimming between adjacent locations takes three turns.

DROWNING IN THE COLD WATERS of the bay is a real risk. CON check when falling in, and every following turn, with the following modifiers.

backpack	-2	two-handed	
leather armor	-2	weapon	-1
chain	-4	sailor’s yellow	
plate	-6	jacket	+4.
shield	-1	Dwarf	-1d6

A failed check entails 1d4 damage. Drowning damage is recovered after a night’s rest in a dry place.

ARRIVAL

The merchantman drops anchor off the coast of Isla Requia and you begin rowing. Between the high red cliffs, the dark harbor waters lap hungrily at the shattered hulls of the Radiant fleet. The harbor is also thick with flotsam, rafts, and islands. On the far side of the harbor lies a low beach.

➤ **Merchantman.** The ship immediately returns to port, and then comes back every three days at noon to look for you. If the characters don’t row out to the ship by the fifth visit (15 days), Captain Placida assumes they have died and stops returning.

➤ **Rowing.** The party is given a longboat that can safely seat ten people. There are four oars, and one small anchor on a 30-foot rope.

➤ **Shattered hulls.** Warships from Radiant Vitela, destroyed two weeks ago.

➤ **Beach.** Sandy and rocky. A recently built shanty town of huts and tents. No dock.



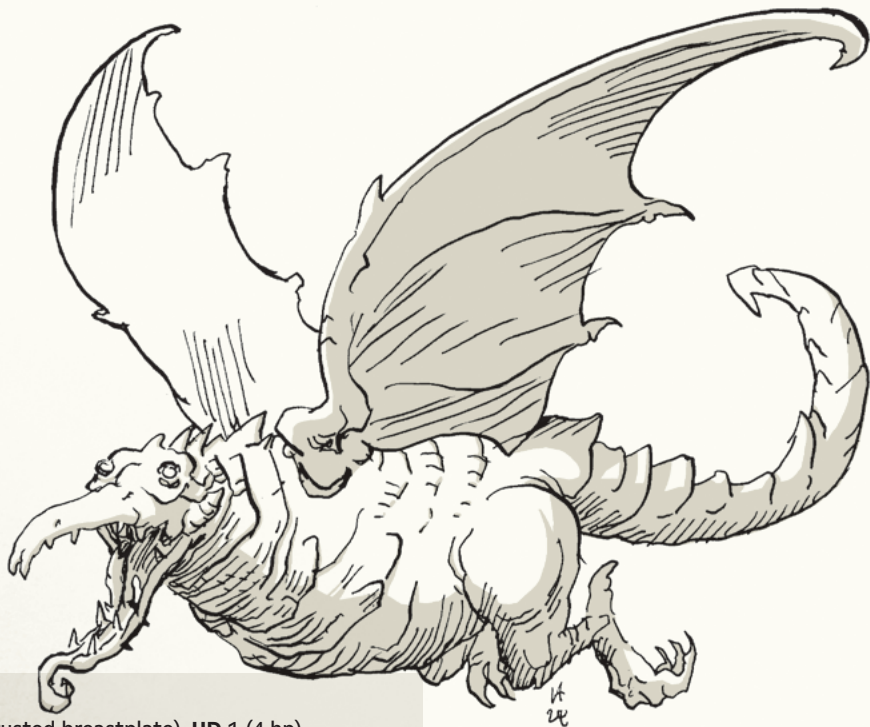
- 1. Capsized cutter
- 2. Wrecked frigate
- 3. Red glow
- 4. Two masts
- 5. White island
- 6. Black island

- 7. Fallen lighthouse
- 8. Colossus
- 9. Anchored raft
- 10. Tethered raft
- 11. Wriggling shape

Encounters in the harbor

Roll 1d20 for an encounter each time the party rows toward a new destination.

- 1 A human scream echoes out across the water.
- 2 Three **skeletons** climb up on a nearby rock and leap onto the party's boat!
- 3 Two **kettle crabs** swim to the surface and nip at the party's oars and hands.
- 4 A hideous **vulgrane** swoops down to make clawing passes over the adventurer's boat!
- 5 Three **harbor sharks** ram the boat, trying to flip it!
- 6 A giant blue tentacle rises out of the waves and smashes a nearby shipwreck, then slips back down beneath the dark harbor waters.
- 7 A lone **sailor** (*Carlo*) in a yellow jacket paddles a raft, calling for help. The fin of a **harbor shark** circles the fragile craft.
- 8 Four desperate, starving **sailors** in yellow jackets row a longboat out toward the party. They have cutlasses drawn. (*Leo, Donato, Marco, Paul*)
A green bottle bobs on the waves. A scrap of paper is rolled up inside it: "*Dearest Olivia, we were destroyed by foul sorcery before ever reaching land. We cling to a rock now. The sharks are closing in. Each day, someone dies. So go on, marry my brother, if you want. I don't care anymore. Love, Bruno.*"
- 9
Five **harbor sharks** thrash just below the surface. A few logs and a yellow jacket bob away. The frothing waves are red (two desperate **sailors** tried to escape on a raft. It sank. They're already dead. The sharks ignore the party unless attacked).
- 10
A sickly white corpse floats by, face down. When touched, it belches foul fumes into the air, all within 10' must save vs poison or take 1d6 damage from the poison.
- 11
A large turtle with a gleaming black shell glides languidly through the water. It raises its head to reveal a human face. Once a person, they have lost the ability to reason or talk.
- 12
Two **vulgranes** fighting over a bloody man fall out of the sky, splashing down beside the party, thrashing wildly. The man screams, then plunges under. (**Sailor Ivano**, yellow jacket, saw a strange red flash from the top of the Keep just before the red storm began).
- 13
A raft floats by. Three **kettle crabs** scuttle about on it, tearing open a body wearing a yellow jacket. Silver gleams in the dead sailor's hand (angelfire grenade).
- 14
A rowboat bobs past, flipped upside down. It appears to be traveling in a straight line. Hidden underneath are two **Keep soldiers** in blue uniforms (**Cosmo** and **Delia**) trying to escape the island. They reveal it is possible to enter the Keep through a hidden hatch in a grassy hillside (p. 32) to the west of the walls and provide a **black iron key** to open it.
- 15
A brief beam of sunlight illuminates the sandy bottom below the party's boat, revealing 3d6 **skeletons** walking about on the sea floor (15' down). These undead sailors are excavating a large chest from the muck (containing seven black pearls worth 200 GP each and 6,000 SP).
- 16
A dozen pale dolphins swim into the harbor, circle three times around the party's boat, and then hurry back out to sea. This is the only warning they can give.
- 17
A seagull lands on the party's boat. Then two more. Then a dozen more. They sit and stare. Hungrily. They scream a few times. Any sudden movement from the party scares them off.
- 18
A small black cloud drifts down over the party's boat and lets a cold torrent of rain fall on them for half an hour before it drifts away again. The boat is half-filled with water, at risk of capsizing or sinking unless bailed out.
- 19
Red lightning flickers in the dark storm clouds that hover over the Keep. The thunder that follows sounds like an unholy mixture of lions roaring and pigs squealing.
- 20



SKELETON

AC 7 [12] (rusted breastplate), **HD** 1 (4 hp), **Att** 1 × weapon (1d6 or by weapon), **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 12, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 10 ▶ **Undead:** Make no noise, until they attack. Immune to effects that affect living creatures (e.g. poison). Immune to mind-affecting or mind-reading spells (e.g. charm, hold, sleep).

VULGRANE - *Vulgranes are large black saurians with leathery wings and a long toothy maw. They are cruel and cowardly. Their calls sometimes sound like very rude mockeries.*

AC 7 [12], **HD** 2* (9 hp), **Att** 1 × talon (1d6), **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 90' (30') / 180' (60') flying, **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 6, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 25

▶ **Dive attack:** First attack has +2 to hit.

▶ **Soaring doom:** 1-in-6 chance on each successful attack to snatch the target from the ground and toss them 30 feet away (2d6 damage).

❖ **LOOT!** The bile of Vulgranes is sought after by alchemists who make beard oil of charming with it (30 GP per individual bile sac).

KEEP SOLDIER

AC 5 [14] (black chainmail), **HD** 2 (9 hp), **Att** 1 × guisarme (1d10) or by weapon, **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 60' (20') **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 7, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 20

HARBOR SHARK

AC 7 [12], **HD** 2 (9 hp), **Att** 1 × bite (1d6+2), **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 180' (60') **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 20

▶ **Blood scent:** Can detect blood in water up to 300' away.

▶ **Feeding frenzy:** Triggered by the scent of blood — always attack; no morale checks.

KETTLE CRAB - *Imposing ball of chitinous carapace, as big as a dog, from which emerge colorful, sharp pincers and six voracious eyes on peduncles.*

AC 5 [14], **HD** 2 (9 hp), **Att** 2 × pincer (2d4), **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 20

❖ **LOOT!** 2-in-6 chance to recover a pincer in good enough condition to be sold as a souvenir in any port city (35 GP)

SAILOR

AC 7 [12] (yellow leather), **HD** 1 (4 hp), **Att** 1 × cutlass (1d6) or by weapon, **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 120' (40') **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 6, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 10

▶ Strong swimmer, good at swearing.

Unless otherwise specified in the following paragraphs or on p. 13, use the following stats for all 'normal humans' encountered:

AC 9 [10] (unarmored), **HD** ½ (2hp), **Att** 1 × weapon (1d6 or by weapon), **THACO** 20 [-1], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D14 W15 P16 B17 S18, **ML** 6, **AL** Any, **XP** 5

1. Capsized cutter

An overturned hull rests above the waves on a rocky point. From a square hole in one side, a woman sits fishing.

➤ **Hull.** *Golden Dove.*

➤ **Square hole.** Clearly sawed out recently.

➤ **Woman.** *Rosetta*, 55, tough as nails, healthy, yellow jacket sailor. Says the ships were destroyed by red lightning. Most sailors eaten by sharks. Asks for rescue.

➤ **Inside the ship.** Behind Rosetta's bedding and tools, there is a neat stack of nine swords and daggers, including one ornate cutlass.

ADMIRAL'S CUTLASS - This magic weapon (as short sword +1) has an ornate golden hilt with white coral spikes. The bearer can cast *remove fear* / *cause fear* (1/day).

2. Wrecked frigate

A barnacle-crusting hull lies impaled on the sharp rocks. On one side, a charred hole gapes open. Voices echo inside.

➤ **Hull.** *Hammer of Faith.*

➤ **Charred hole.** 20 feet wide. Exploded outward.

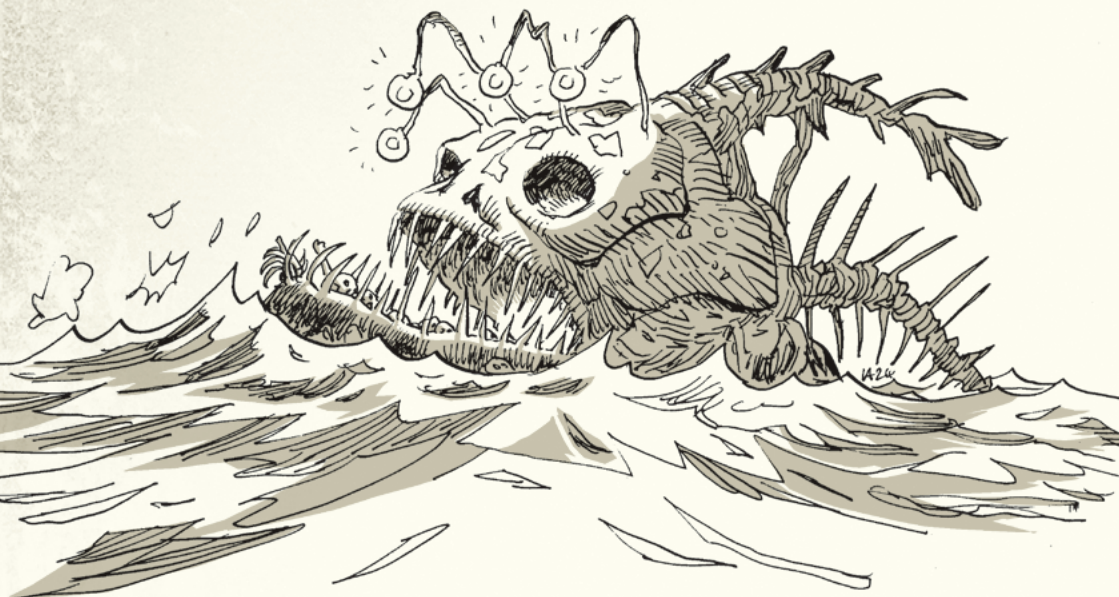
➤ **Voices.** Two gaunt sailors (p. 13) in ragged yellow jackets argue loudly. *Antony* fears storms. *Filipe* fears sharks. They beg to be saved.

• **Inside:** Mostly empty. Lower deck is submerged. Six electric eels nest around a water-tight cask labeled with runes for "danger". Contains 12 angelfire grenades.

ANGELFIRE GRENADE - Apple-sized silver sphere. Twist to arm, three seconds to boom (2d6). Can ignite or shatter nearby materials.

ELECTRIC EEL

AC 9 [10], **HD** 1* (4 hp), **Att** 1 × bite (1d6), 1 × shock and stunned for 1 rd, **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 120' (40') **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 13



3. Red glow

Waves and sloshing debris echo in a narrow **black cave** in the cliff wall. A dim **red light** flickers from inside.

- **Black cave.** Too narrow for a boat. Characters must climb along the narrow slippery ledges in the walls above the water.
- **Red light.** 30 feet back, a dented **bronze lantern** rocks in the waves, casting a red light.

MARINER'S LANTERN - The dim red glow from this magic lantern offers little light, but it clears away fog for 100 feet in all directions.

4. Two masts

Two masts rise above the waves. Twenty feet down, a **broken hull** rests on the sand. **Figures** move in the shadows. **Metal** glints in the light.

- **Hull.** *Shining Lady*.
- **Figures.** Twelve skeletons (p. 13) in tattered yellow uniforms. Shuffling, trapped inside by a tangle of drifting ropes and canvas.
- **Metal.** 2,500 GP glitters under the skeletons' feet. Also, four **angelfire** grenades.

5. White island

The titanic skull of an imperial **shrikefish** rests on the low rocks. Ribcages and **rags** hang from its slender fangs. A **voice** sings softly inside the skull.

- **Shrikefish.** A gigantic anglerfish with four glowing lures and harpoon-like teeth. Never seen alive.
- **Rags.** Yellow sailor jackets.
- **Voice.** Lounging in a sheltered pool is an ursaloth, half woman and half octopus, named **Angelica**. She offers secrets and gifts, for a price.
 - **Give her a kiss:** "Forza was always in control of her powers. But the red storm was all chaos. Beware! There is something very old in that palace. I fear only the angels could cleanse it."

► **Feed her a finger:** the stump grows into a tentacle and the character can now breathe in water as well as air. The boon of the ursaloth!

- **Hidden loot:** Angelica sits on a small rusty chest full of 77 silver forks and 23 jade statuettes of dancing mouselings worth 500 GP.

ANGELICA THE URSALOTH - An amphibious enchantress with octopus tentacles for legs.

AC 3 [16], **HD** 2** (9 hp), **Att** 3 x tentacle (1d4) or unwanted kiss, **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 30

► **Unwanted Kisses:** +4 to hit an unwary or surprised target. Her lips are toxic, save vs poison or die in d6 turns.

► **Seductive Song:** Her voice is sultry, save vs spells or be charmed to protect and obey her. Killing her breaks the charm.

► **Hungry Friends:** She summons two **harbor sharks** (p. 13) to defend her (1/day).

6. Black island

A flat table of black stone rises just above the frothing waves. A lone **shack** huddles against a rock wall. Two **robed men** fumble with a fishing net.

- **Shack.** Flotsam, canvas. Has random cookery, fishing gear, tattered uniforms.
- **Robed men.** Radiant priests in yellow robes. Squabbling, clumsy, skinny. From the *Shining Lady* (two masts).
 - **Ivan**, 55, gray beard, friar of Fate. "Free will is a myth!"
 - **Matteo**, 35, black beard, friar of Fortune. "Everything is our own damned fault!"
 - **Claims:** the fleet was destroyed by unnatural red lightning. Also claim to have heard an "unholy scream of ultimate betrayal" during the storm.
 - **Begs:** for rescue.

RADIANT PRIESTS.

AC 5 [14] (chainmail), **HD** 2* (7 hp), **Att** 1 x mace (1d6) **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 90' (30'), **SV** D11 W12 P14 B16 S15 (C2), **ML** 5, **AL** Lawful, **XP** 25

► **Spells:** As 2nd level cleric

► **Turning undead:** As 2nd level cleric

7. Fallen lighthouse

Black rocks form a jetty spearing out from the pebbled beach. The broken foundations of a **tower** stand in the foam.

► **Tower.** Five **kettle crabs** (p. 13) scuttle inside, picking at the **corpses** of four soldiers in black armor.

► **Corpses.** A **black iron key** hangs on a chain around one soldier's neck.

BLACK IRON KEY - Opens the hatch in the Grassy hillside (p. 33).

8. Colossus

A stone warrior 50 feet tall stands carved into the cliff wall, its left arm shattered at the shoulder. The stone arm lies in the water, its closed **fist** just above the waves.

► **Fist.** A thin gleam of gold is visible between the stone fingers. Takes d6 turns to smash open (2-in-6 chance of an encounter each each turn). Encloses a **gold staff**.

HOLY STAFF OF VITELA - This emerald-studded golden staff was once carried by the archbishops of radiant vitela. The bearer takes half damage from Chaotic magic. Touch the staff to a Chaotic creature to banish it from this plane of existence (1/day).

9. Anchored raft

A large raft of mismatched timbers rides at anchor in the shallows. A sturdy **hut** stands on top. Two **adults** and three **boys** sit fishing.

► **Hut.** Simple, clean. Comfy hammocks. Clothes, tools, and food hang in small nets.

► **Adults.** *Alfeo* and *Velia*, 35, married, local fishermen. Cottage destroyed by lava in the red storm. Eager for news. A nice happy couple.

► **Boys.** *Beppe*, *Dino*, and *Elmo*. 5, 7 and 10 years old. Sleepy, whiny, mischievous.

► **Offer them supplies:** *Alfeo* takes the character aside and says that Duchess *Forza* probably used her sorcery to create the red storm to destroy the fleet.

But then lava destroyed the palace and the fishermen's cottages. The Duchess would never do anything like that!

► **Request:** *Velia* gives a toy boat made by the three boys. It is a gift for **Oskor**, their grandfather, wherever he is. The beach, maybe (**Stilt hut**, p. 20)?

10. Tethered raft

Three small fishing **boats** bob and thump, tethered together against the mast of a sunken ship. An **old man** waves at you.

► **Boats.** A makeshift raft. Fraying ropes, rusty tools, tattered nets.

► **Old man.** *Gasparo*, 60, white hair, visible burn scars. Cannot speak clearly at all, damaged tongue. Injured by lightning in the red storm.

► **Offer him supplies:** He gifts an oilskin case he found full of letters between the Archbishop of Radiant Vitela and Captain Marcus of the Sacred Flame:

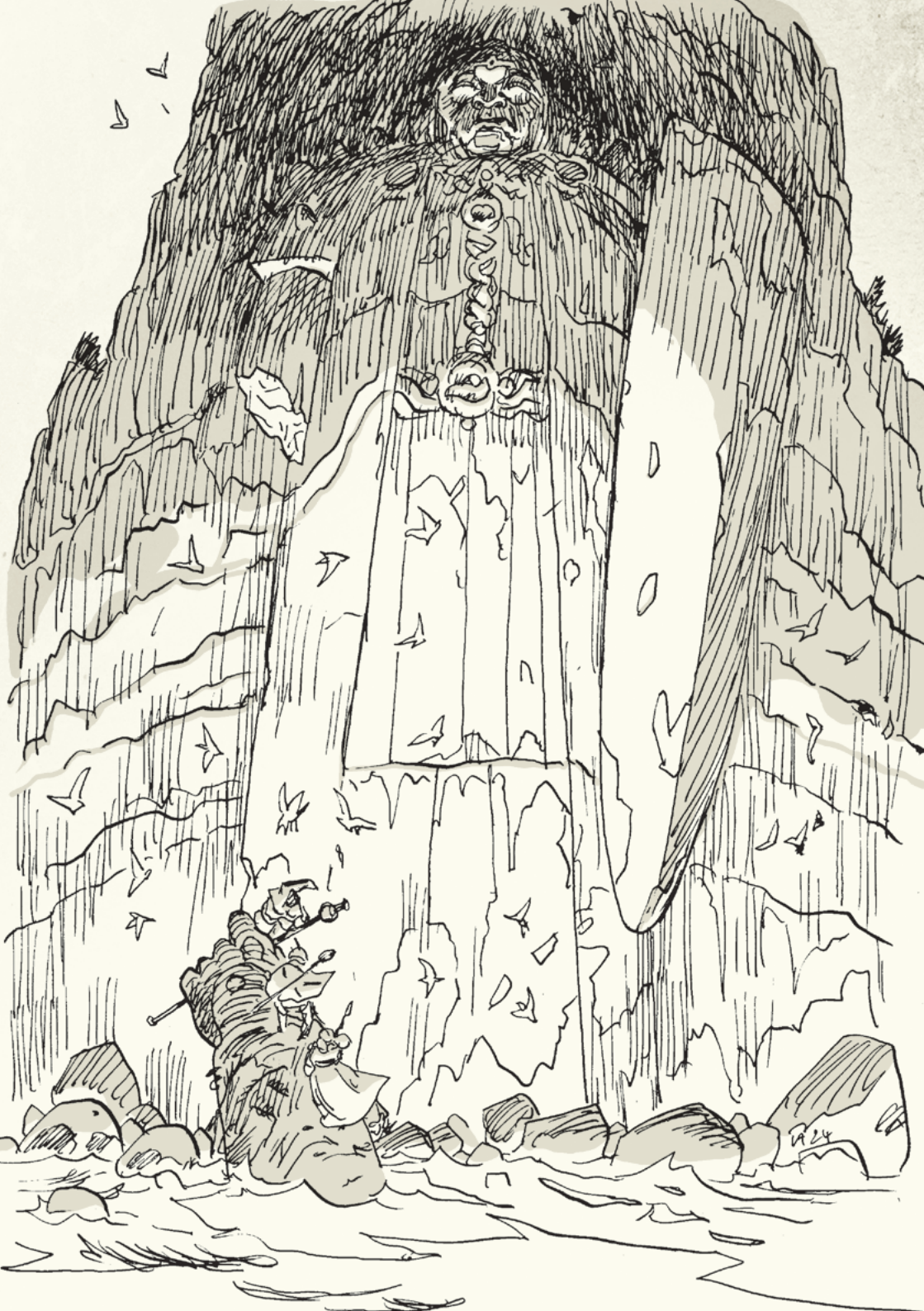
"In addition to destroying the Obsidian Keep and its foul masters, you must also cleanse the world of the hideous servants of the conqueror worm. Strike quickly! Do not even allow them to speak. If any man hears the lies of the red priests, then that man must die as well..."

11. Wriggling shape

A **mass** of tiny legs and tails wriggles on the surface, but makes no progress in any direction.

► **Mass:** Fifty tadpoles have fused together into one mindless, harmless creature.

► **If the party returns later,** half the tadpoles have become full-grown frogs. Still harmless.



SURVIVOR BEACH

Where is this place?

The beach between the harbor and the Obsidian Keep (one mile wide and about three miles long).

What is here?

A shanty town of huts, shacks, and tents.

Who is here?

Some survivors: local fishermen, palace servants, and outsiders (scholar, scavengers).

What do they know?

► Fishermen:

- Are healthy and strong.
- Their cottages at the top of the beach were destroyed by lava during the red storm.
- In small groups, they are building rafts and leaving to find new homes away from Isla Requia.

► Palace servants:

- Have physical mutations from living in the palace over the last year.
- Were saved by Prince Orsino during the red storm. If asked about the prince, they point to the Red Tree (p. 23).
- Do not have the skills to survive on the beach. They are scared and desperate for help or rescue.
- Duchess Forza was a powerful magician, and her husband Duke Avito was obsessed with the occult.

ARRIVAL

The cold harbor waters slosh quietly on the pebbled shore. Dozens of shacks and tents dot the beach. Up the slope, the half-buried ruins of countless cottages sit in the shadow of the Obsidian Keep.

- **Cottages.** Stone, humble homes of the fisher folk. All half-buried in cooled lava.
- **Obsidian Keep.** Three miles away, up a steep slope.

1. Cave hut

Sheltered from the elements, a ship's intact cabin rests inside this shallow cave. A man and girl sit, braiding ropes and nets.

- **Man.** *Sandro*, 35, healthy, friendly. Fisherman. Hates the mutant servants, glad Duchess Forza and Duke Avito are gone.
- **Girl.** *Nora*, 10, healthy, sarcastic. Wants to hear stories about monsters!

2. Overturned dinghy

A small dinghy rests upside down on driftwood poles. A man digs in the sand nearby.

- **Man.** *Ivo*. 45, Healthy, bored, over-eager for company, lifelong clam digger. Ready to sail off in search of a new home.

► **Requests:** Ivo needs an intact sail. If given one, he says, “*you can get under the palace through a tunnel under the western wall. It leads straight into the dungeons. You’ll need a black iron key, but only soldiers have those.*” (see Grassy Hillside, p. 33)

Unless otherwise specified in the following paragraphs (or on p. 13), use the following stats for all ‘normal humans’ encountered

AC 9 [10] (unarmored), **HD** 1½ (2 hp), **Att** 1 × weapon (1d6 or by weapon), **THAC0** 20 [–1], **MV** 120’ (40’), **SV** D14 W15 P16 B17 S18 (NH), **ML** 6, **AL** Any, **XP** 5

Encounters on the beach

Roll 1d20 for an encounter each time the party moves toward a new destination.

- 1 A screaming cackle echoes down from the palace.
- 2 A corpse washes onto the shore. Its chest bursts open. A dozen **eels** spill out and race for the water.
- 3 A straight row of six unmarked mounds in the damp sand (crude graves of mutated servants).
- 4 Two **kettle crabs** lie dead in the sand: their red chitin shattered open, their pale meat taken.
- 5 Four **kettle crabs** emerge from the sand to surround the characters.
- 6 A hideous **vulgrane** swoops down to make clawing passes over the party's heads!
- 7 Three huge, black **vulgranes** soar in lazy circles above the beach, waiting for something to die, and occasionally dropping a foul yellow spatter (highly flammable scat — treat as lamp oil).
- 8 A giant mass of milky, white flesh lies quivering on the beach (d6 lightning damage when touched).
A small gang of unsupervised filthy children stomp along the water's edge, stabbing beached jellyfish with sharp sticks and shouting swear words. Their parents died in the red storm. They know where the backdoor to the palace is ([Grassy Hillside](#), p. 33). They demand to be rescued from the island.
- 10 The ground shakes and a rift opens at party's feet, spilling searing hot lava onto the beach (d6 damage).
- 11 A red horseshoe crab crawls up the beach. On its underside, there is a woman's horrified face surrounded by chitinous legs.
- 12 A shark lies still on the sand, its belly swollen. In its stomach is a golden helmet (worth 250 GP) with a man's surprised head still inside it.
- 13 Dozens of tiny white sandpipers land on the beach and toddle forward. Each has one large red eye. They abruptly dash about, yanking fat white worms from the sand to swallow them whole. Then fly away.
- 14 A tall, slender gray heron walks elegantly along the beach in a perfectly straight line. Its wings are featherless, red ruins. It cries sorrowfully, chokes, and falls dead. In its throat, a silver ring with a diamond shaped like a scarab (300 GP).
- 15 Hundreds of fist-sized white clams cluster among a few large gray rocks, draped in green kelp. Inside each shell is a live human eye that fixes on the nearest face. When swallowed whole, they cause the eater to grow a working eye somewhere on their body.
- 16 A body crawls down the beach toward the water. Three women and two men all fused together in a wretched tangle of limbs and heads, faces gasping and weeping. Some beg for help. Some beg for death.
- 17 A cluster of tiny blue jellyfish float gently through the air at chest level (20' cloud). Tentacles cause painful stings and welts (1 damage). Fragile.
- 18 The beach grows hot underfoot, and suddenly a dozen crooked spears of milky, brown glass lance upward at wild angles (d6 damage, save vs paralysis to avoid).
- 19 Three grim sailors in dirty yellow jackets sit shivering around a small fire of driftwood. They look up with pleading eyes. They have no mouths. They will starve to death in 2d6 days.
- 20 A great mound of brown and yellow bones (human) sits high on a dune. A pair of adorable sea otters scamper in and out of a small entrance as they forage for food and then return to their macabre shelter. Inside, three even more adorable baby sea otters frolic on dried kelp beside 419 GP in loose coins, pearl earrings, jade bracelets, silver nose rings, and coral necklaces.

Kettle crab, vulgrane and sailor: see p. 13

3. Lava stream

A bright yellow stream of lava flows slowly down the slope from the Obsidian Keep, across the beach, and into the water.

➤ **Stream:** Ten feet wide, a cloud of foul hot steam hovers over it.

➤ **Danger.** 2-in-6 chance of a cinder shrimp swarm.

CINDER SHRIMP (swarm): *Finger-sized crustaceans that live in magma rivers.*

AC 7 [12], **HD** 3 (13 hp), **Att** 1 x swarm (2 or 4 hp), **THACO** 17 [+2], **MV** 30' (10') / 60' (20') swimming, **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 11, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 35

▶ **Size:** 20' × 20' area, typically.

▶ **Swarm attack:** Automatically damages characters within swarm area: 2 hp if wearing armour, 4 hp without. Attacks by latching onto burning prey with their scorching shells.

▶ **Escaping:** On exiting the swarm, characters continue to suffer half damage until 1 full round is spent removing, drowning, or freezing the attached shrimp.

▶ **Immunity:** Immune to fire and heat. Only affected by cold and sleep spells, or other attacks as the referee wishes.

4. Stilt hut

A tiny wooden hut stands on ten-foot stilts above the waves. An old man sits on the platform holding a spear.

➤ **Man.** *Oskor*, 70, healthy, skinny, shirtless, toothless, timid, spear-fisher.

▶ **Drunk:** He passed out and slept through the red storm.

▶ **Misses:** His daughter Velia.

▶ **Give him the toy boat** (see 9. page 20): He gives up drinking and gives away his last bottle of Requira rum (three portions, each causes 8 hours of sleep).

▶ **Don't give him the toy:** He dies of alcohol poisoning within a day.

5. Canvastent

A flimsy tent of patched canvas stands shaking in the breeze. Thumps and shouts ring out!

➤ **Thumps.** A kettle crab (p. 9) is attacking a frightened woman clutching a baby!

➤ **Woman.** *Clio*, 25, tired, hungry, scared (red scales on her left hand), and baby Rico (healthy). She is a palace maid rescued by Prince Orsino during the red storm.

▶ **Claims** she saw dark stains in Duke Avito's laundry for the last few months. Thinks he was very ill, maybe dying. (He was sacrificing animals.)

6. Blackshell

A slimy, barnacle-encrusted shell rises from the wet sand. A silver rune gleams on one side.

➤ **Rune.** "Angelfire"

➤ **Unexploded angelfire shell**, launched by the fleet. 5 foot diameter. 100 pounds. Can be safely moved as long as it is handled gently. One direct strike or drop and boom (6d6 damage to everything within 30 feet).

7. Sandy mound

A crooked mound of sand 30 feet across bulges from the beach. It stinks of salt and decay. Large blood-red crabs scuttle over the mound, digging into the sand.

➤ **Crabs.** Six large kettle crabs (p. 13), very territorial.

➤ **Mound.** Contains 72 dead sailors, buried by beach-folk.

• **Treasure:** 12 Daggers, frayed yellow uniforms, 1 angelfire grenade (p.14), 109 GP.

8. Driftwood shack

A rickety cottage of salvaged driftwood stands on the beach. Three children play outside. Two women mend clothes.

➤ **Cottage.** Two families of palace servants share this home. Prince Orsino led



1. Cave hut

2. Overturned dinghy

3. Lava stream

4. Stilt hut

5. Canvastent

6. Black shell

7. Sandy mound

8. Driftwood shack

9. Gold tent

10. Filthy tent

11. Stone arch

12. Black & red tent

13. Red tree

14. Buried cottages

15. Roaring bonfire

them to safety during the red storm.

➤ **Children.** *Aldo* (elf ear). *Lena* (goat eye). *Gino* (fang).

➤ **Women.** *Flora* (pig nose). *Berta* (gnarled horn).

▶ **Men?** Out looking for food.

▶ **Mutations?** They say the changes started a year ago when Duke Avito began fighting with his wife. He was jealous of her arcane powers.

9. Gold tent

A small tent of gold silk rustles in the breeze. A young man sits outside on an overturned bucket, writing in a book. Jagged chunks of glass sit on the sand around him.

➤ **Man.** Hamza, 25, healthy, beardless, black hair, yellow robes. Black eye from a run-in with the scavengers at the filthy tent (see opposite). Enthusiastic scholar from Radiant Vitela, just arrived yesterday, wants to learn what happened here.

▶ **Requests:** He wants some red glass from the red tree (p. 23), but he is too scared to go near the screaming tree. He offers a pair of black gloves to bring him some red glass.

➤ **Book.** Drawings and notes about the shipwrecks.

➤ **Glass.** Fulgurite samples. Claims the storm was caused by a new, unknown sorcery. Very exciting!

HAMZA'S GLOVES - The wearer of these magic leather gloves can safely touch any object (hot, cold, magical, acid, lava, fire, etc.).

10. Filthy tent

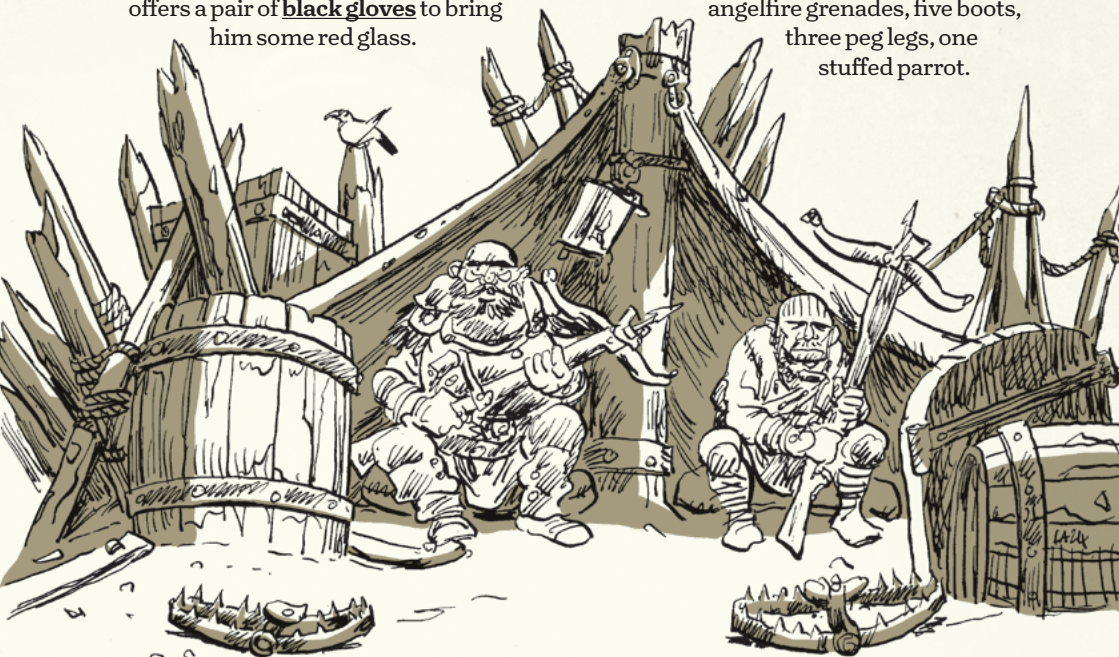
A tent made from a muddy sail lies lashed across a shattered mast. Wood and iron stakes ring the area.

➤ **30 feet from the tent:** a crossbow bolt flies over the character's heads. A man yells, "*Get lost!*"

➤ **15 feet from the tent:** there are six bear traps (d6 damage) buried in the sand all around the tent, 2-in-6 chance to trigger when walking within 15' of the tent.

➤ **Tent.** Occupied by *Dmitri* and *Lazar*, 30, tough, mean. Healthy. Scavengers and thieves.

▶ **Inside:** Locked chest. 1,241 FP, 47 white pearls (2,350 GP), 14 cutlasses, two red pearl earrings (500 GP), two angelfire grenades, five boots, three peg legs, one stuffed parrot.



SCAVENGER - A human with more greed than sense.

AC 2 [17], **HD** 3 (13 hp), **Att** 1 x weapon (1d8), **THACO** 19 [+0], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 6, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 35

- **Weapon:** Short sword, hatchet, hammer, pickaxe, crossbow.
- **Grenado:** d8, blinding flash, ignites dry material, scatters loose material (1 each).
- **Desperado:** The scavenger must make a Morale check each time they are harmed. When they fail, the scavenger tries to flee at all costs.

11. Stone arch

High on the cliff, a stone arch curves over a dim cave. Ancient markings cover the stones.

NOTE: This is the ancient tomb of the magician Prospero. Ten years ago, Duchess Forza took his skull to learn his sorcerous secrets

- **Cliff.** There is no path. Characters must climb the sheer rock face 50 feet straight up.
- **Markings.** Olde common: *"keep out! Danger! It was very hard to kill him! Leave him dead! Please!"*
- **Cave.** Smells of incense. Rough stone. 20 feet back, a stone door stands open, scorch marks on the dirt floor. 40 feet back, a stone sarcophagus lies open, with a skeleton inside. The skull is missing. Scratch marks on the inside of the lid.
- **Sarcophagus:** The lid reads in olde common, *"Here lies Prospero, long may he rot. He dabbled in magic, and look what he got!"*. Hidden in the dusty bone fragments in the sarcophagus there is a platinum ring (200 GP) and a single glass eye.

ARCANE EYE - Cloudy, swirling. The magically preserved eye of the magician Prospero, which contains a sliver of his mind and soul (possessed).

- Touch the eye to an object or creature and Prospero's voice booms from nowhere, identifying or explaining it with dripping sarcasm and obvious prejudice (1/day).

12. Black & red tent

A wide tent of black and red silk stands high on the dunes. A tattooed man sits on a rock. A masked woman lounges on a tattered sofa on the sand.

- **Tent.** Clean and sturdy, but fraying at the edges. Inside, one chest of silverware (80 GP), one chest of jade figurines (80 GP), and a simple cot.
- **Man.** Ezio, 40, beard, rapier. No left ear (he cut it off to remove his mutation). Grim, depressed bodyguard. Knows the lady is mad, but he has nowhere else to go.
- **Woman.** Magdalena, 35, blonde, charming, delusional. Painted porcelain mask hides her mutation (an insane smile stretched to her ears with large beaver teeth). Once a wealthy jade merchant and lady at court.
- **Wants:** Attention.
- **Claims:** This is all a mistake and Duke Avito and Duchess Forza will return to restore the Obsidian Keep soon.
- **Requests:** Thieves stole her red pearl earrings last week (see Filthy tent, p. 22). She offers 1,000 GP reward for them (she has no money).

13. Red tree

A twisted, branching pillar of milky red glass rises from the sand. A black skeleton stands frozen inside it. A silver circlet rests on the skull.

- **30 feet from the pillar.** Muted screaming.
- **Pillar.** Fulgurite. Caused by a huge lightning strike.
- **Skeleton.** Naked, charred, frozen in a pose of pain.
- **Circlet.** Pure silver set with three black pearls (1,000 gp).
- **Touch it:** the dead Prince Orsino begs you to break the glass and bury his bones, in return for his story and the secret of his circlet.



► **Orsino's story:** *"During the red storm, I couldn't find my little sister Bianca anywhere. My eldest sister Viola sent me to lead the servants to safety. I did so, but I was struck by lightning here. I've seen Mother's sorcerous powers many times, and this was like nothing she had ever done before. I find it difficult to believe this was her doing. I blame the red priests, but I do not know how they did this. Please find my sister Bianca!"*

ORSINO'S CIRCLET.

► **When placed in its case in Prince Orsino's room** (p. 60): It summons a sylph (tiny gray six-winged moth-man, intelligent but does not speak) cleric, which heals whoever last touched Orsino's circlet (d6 hp, cures poison and ends diseases, once per day).

► **While worn:**

- Gain +1 WIS.
- Disables the trap at the door of Bianca's room (p. 62).

14. Buried cottages

Half buried in the cooled lava, 50 stone cottages are still partially visible along the bluffs above the beach. No signs of life here now.

15. Roaring bonfire

Above the high-tide line, a heap of driftwood, splintered planks, and shredded canvas burns brightly, hurling cinders into the air. Two dozen dirty strangers talk quietly, staring into the flames. A fair number wear yellow jackets or leather smocks, but you notice a variety of armour and outfits from around the known world.

► **Yellow jackets.** Stranded sailors from Radiant Vitela (p. 9). Gaunt, ragged. Desperate for rescue. Willing to do anything to escape this cursed island.

► **Leather smocks.** Homeless servants from the Obsidian Keep. Superficial

mutations (fur, scales, feathers). Oddly serene, content. Glad to be free of their masters. Hopeful about their future. Willing to help the party for a little extra coin and passage off the island (see pp. 70-71).

► **Discussing:** How difficult or dangerous it would be to either build a boat from the flotsam, or to steal a houseboat from someone in the harbor. Each day there is a 2-in-6 chance they work up the nerve to try an escape plan.





AT THE FOOT OF THE OBSIDIAN KEEP

Where is this place?

On a steep promontory, at the edge of a 300-foot cliff battered by winds and waves.

What is here?

Ruined castle, corpses, and some monsters.

Who is here?

A couple of insane mutant palace servants, *Silvio* (**Armored cottage**, p. 31) and *Durante* (**Kitchen**, p. 32).

What do they know?

Duchess Forza was at the height of her powers and genius. She was going to rule the seven cities of the Sakeen Sea with her mighty sorcery.

But there was a rift with Duke Avito. He was jealous of his wife. He surrounded himself with strange red robed priests and spent most of his time in private, starting a year ago.

ARRIVAL

Through a veil of falling ash, you see a wasteland of charred **ruins**. Magma creeps through **rifts** in the earth. Cooled lava covers the walls like blackened tumors. **Dead men** lie burned and buried in the volcanic rock. Amid the wreckage, a stone cottage tumbles slowly in mid-air, and a shining **black keep** stands beneath an unending torrential **rainstorm**.

➤ **Ruins.** Stone buildings of various sizes built against the castle walls in the courtyard leading to the keep.

➤ **Rifts.** Five feet wide. Hot.

➤ **Dead men.** Soldiers in black armor. A hundred of them. Killed by the eruption during the Red Storm, crushed and burned.

➤ **Black keep.** Towering baroque architecture in black stone on several storeys, overlooking the courtyard and the cliffs.

➤ **Rainstorm.** Unnatural, Chaotic.

Restricted to the Obsidian Keep itself. It will not stop raining unless Vermesh is banished from this reality.





1. Southgate
2. Standing tower
3. Fallen tower
4. Floating cottage
5. Stables
6. Cages
7. Armored cottage

8. White garden
9. Shed
10. Kitchen
11. Burnt rooms
12. Main entrance
13. Grassy hillside

Encounters in the courtyard

Roll 1d20 for an encounter each time the party moves toward a new destination.

- 1 A legless skeleton crawls past and tumbles into a fiery rift.
- 2 Huge, glowing bubbles of scorching lava swell up and burst, again and again, spraying searing droplets of molten rock in every direction (1d4 damage per round if close).
- 3 Pebbles, hay, and other loose detritus floats up languidly into the air, hovers for a minute, and then crashes back down to the ground.
- 4 A mass of **cinder shrimp** swarm up from the lava and skitter toward the beach. If they are allowed to leave, then there are screams from the beach 1 turn later from one of the tents (1d3: 1 black and red; 2 gold; 3 filthy)
- 5 The hardened lava crumbles underfoot. Save vs paralysis or fall into a jagged 10-foot hole (1d6).
- 6 A mound of igneous rock cracks open and three **obsidian skeletons** crawl up onto the ashen soil, confused and easily angered.
- 7 An **obsidian skeleton** chips diligently at a lump of hardened lava where two more skeletons are trapped, hissing unintelligibly.
- 8 A **flailing mass** of fused human bodies crawls toward you on its burnt limbs, wailing and babbling.
- 9 A giant armored **ash louse** erupts from the ground and begins snuffling about for loose ash and dust to eat.
- 10 An enormous mass of pale segmented flesh lies still on the glowing molten rock (a dead ash louse). A dozen **ember pucks** tug at the stringy flesh inside, chewing on the tough ribbons before tossing them aside. These 'processed' fibers can be used to draw poison out of open wounds.
- 11 A pale figure in black armor lies with a sword through its belly. As you approach, the **ghastly soldier** pulls the sword free and cries, "*For the Duchess!*"
- 12 Four **ghastly soldiers** march in formation. One stumbles and they all fall in a tangle of bones and armor. They grunt and snarl, slashing wildly in all directions.
- 13 Two tiny glowing **ember pucks** flutter up above the party. Giggling madly, they begin to mutter an incantation...
- 14 Ten feet above the courtyard, a speckled brown horse hovers in the air, tumbling slowly and whickering sadly. A soldier in black armor hangs tangled in the saddle, lifeless (plate mail, long sword, shield, saddlebag containing 30 GP and a curved green dagger shaped like a scorpion's tail that poisons one successful hit per day - save or die, the wielder must save on a natural 1).
- 15 Lightning strikes the high gothic black buttresses of the Obsidian Keep, sending a spray of cold water and shattered stone down into the courtyard (save vs paralysis or d6 damage).
- 16 A howling wind blows through the perpetual rain storm over the Obsidian Keep. For 1 turn, cold rain falls on into the open lava rivers, filling the air with hot blinding steam.
- 17 Three soldiers in black armor lie dead under a jagged block of black masonry (fallen from the Obsidian Keep). The stonework is hot to the touch, and covered in tiny red worms that whisper and hiss, "*Ver... Mesh... Ver...Mesh...*"
- 18 A shaggy gray wolf hound lies at the edge of a fiery rift, pawing weakly as it slips backwards into the burning abyss. A swarm of **Cinder Shrimp** cover its rear legs and back. The dying hound's wide dark eyes beg for release.

19 Two gaunt servants in filthy, drenched clothing stumble across the courtyard carrying a large ironbound chest. They freeze at the sight of the party. Depending on the reaction roll, they might run towards the beach with the chest, or drop it and look for a way back inside. They may threaten the party but they will not fight. Inside the chest, 798 GP of silverware, candle sticks, silk scarves, silk gloves, stilettos, black leather boots, and black tricorne hats.

20 A thousand red ravens (with no eyes) descend from the sky and perch on every rooftop and wall around the courtyard. They watch the party proceed. When the party suffers a loss or setback, the red ravens laugh loudly. When the party succeeds in some way, the red ravens shout angrily and hot blood rains from the sky for 1 turn.

CINDER SHRIMP (swarm) - *Finger-sized crustaceans that live in magma rivers.*

AC 7 [12], **HD** 3 (13hp), **Att** 1 x swarm (2 or 4 hp),

THACO 17 [+2], **MV** 30' (10') / 60' (20') swimming,

SV D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 11, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 35

► **Size:** 20' × 20' area, typically.

► **Immunity:** Immune to fire and heat. Only harmed by extreme cold and sleep spells, or other attacks as the referee wishes.

► **Swarm attack:** Automatically damages characters within swarm area: 2hp if wearing armour, 4hp without. Attack by latching onto burning prey with their scorching shells.

► **Escaping:** On exiting the swarm, characters continue to suffer half damage until 1 full round is spent removing, drowning, or freezing the attached shrimp.

FLAILING MASS - *A dozen human bodies fused together by terrible heat and rampant Chaos. It tumbles and skitters on burnt arms and legs, its many melted faces staring and screaming. Incapable of thought or speech, driven by pain, confusion, and fury.*

AC 5 [14], **HD** 5* (22 hp), **Att** 1 x flailing limbs (2d6), insane whispers, **THACO** 14 [+5], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D10 W11 P12 B13 S14, **ML** 12, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 300

► **Insane Whispers:** 5' radius, Save vs Spells or take 1d6 and spend next turn staggering and babbling.

ASH LOUSE - *An elephantine arachnid with eight grasping legs and a bulbous thorax glowing with super-heated acidic bile. Wades in magma rivers, always covered in a thin layer of fresh ash. Blood-thirsty and territorial.*

AC 5 [14], **HD** 4 (18 hp), **Att** 1 x bite (2d4), bitter spray, **THACO** 15 [+4], **MV** 90' (30'), **SV** D10 W11 P12 B13 S14, **ML** 9, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 175

► **Bitter spray:** Every third round, 15' cone, save vs breath or take 2d6 poison damage

OBSIDIAN SKELETON - *A burnt human skeleton covered in jagged shards of black volcanic glass. Only a glimmer of memory animates it, driven to familiar places and violent habits.*

AC 7 [12] (obsidian shards), **HD** 2 (7 hp),

Att 1 x charred gladius (1d6 +1), 1 x scorched spear (1d6 +3), **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 12, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 20

► **Undead:** Make no noise, until they attack. Immune to effects that affect living creatures (e.g. poison). Immune to mind-affecting or mind-reading spells (e.g. charm, hold, sleep).

GHASTLY SOLDIER - *A slaughtered warrior dying in slow motion, their putrescent flesh rotting away from crumbling bones, their tortured mind unable to accept their horrifically fatal state.*

AC 5 [14] (mostly dead), **HD** 2* (7 hp), **Att** 1 x sword (1d8), stench, **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 90' (30'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 12, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 25

► **Stench:** 5' radius. Save vs poison or take 1d6 damage.

► **Undead:** Make no noise, until they attack. Immune to effects that affect living creatures (e.g. poison). Immune to mind-affecting or mind-reading spells (e.g. charm, hold, sleep).

EMBER PUCK - *A small winged monkey made of living charcoal, with blazing eyes and veins of fire. Playful, cowardly, and cruel.*

AC 5 [14], **HD** 1** (4 hp), **Att** 1 x claw (1d6) or cast heat metal (1d6) or death burst, **THACO** 15 [+4], **MV** 90' (30'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 12, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 16

► **Death burst:** 5' radius, save vs breath or take 2d6 damage.

► **Resistance:** Fire, half damage.

► **Vulnerability:** Cold, double damage.

1. South gate

The black **walls** of the palace loom over you, the tops jagged and broken. Rubble blocks the mangled **gate**. An elegant black **carriage** lies crushed under fallen debris. Sulfurous fumes rise from the earth.

- **Walls.** 50 feet tall. Large stones have fallen from the top but it is otherwise intact.
- **Gate.** Iron. Bent, will never open again.
- **Carriage.** Leaving the palace. Decaying horse and driver. Inside, dead gentleman in black velvet suit in a white porcelain mask. No nose under it. . Snuff box, full of **red dust**, blue pearl key (**blue pearl door**, p. 47), **letter**.

RED ORCHID DUST - inhale and giggle uncontrollably for 2d6 turns. Anyone who hears the giggle must save vs paralysis or begin giggling until you stop. Speech and spellcasting are impossible.

LETTER FROM DUKE AVITO - To the invading fleet: "Surrender or be devoured by the conqueror worm!"

2. Standing tower

This round black **tower** glowers over the walls, its roof charred and shattered.

- **Tower.** Roof charred and shattered.
- ▶ **Entrance:** Open archway on the inner wall.
- ▶ **Interior:** Stone stairs spiral up to a landing. Black armor on charred skeletons (lightning).
- ▶ **Loot!** Seven black longbows, seven black breastplates, 37 arrows, and one black iron key (opens **Grassy hillside**, p. 37).

3. Fallen tower

Rubble lies around a smoking volcanic vent where the wall used to stand. Bright lava oozes down to the beach. Armored **corpses** lie everywhere.

- **Corpses:** Dead soldiers in melted armor, buried in hard lava.
- **Rubble:** Possible to climb over rubble to enter the grounds. Beware the searing heat and **toxic fumes** from the lava.
- **Toxic fume:** Save vs poison or spend 2d6 turns coughing loudly and unable to see clearly beyond ten feet.

4. Floating cottage

Twenty feet above the ground, the crushed shape of a stone **cottage**, torn out from the wall by the red storm, floats 30 feet in the air, slowly tumbling in place. The **stones** sizzle and spark.

- **Stones.** Residual charge. One touch releases a loud shock (1d6 damage), which removes the charge.
- **Cottage.** Home and shop of a cobbler. An open window offers a narrow path inside, should someone make their way up.
- ▶ **Interior:** Cobbler's tools, raw leather, nine assorted shoes, and one **black leather jacket**.

BLACK LEATHER JACKET - Striking. Sexy. Cool. All of the wearer's reaction rolls are coin tosses (heads = total success and tails = horrific failure).

5. Stables

Volcanic rock covers the floor inside the blackened stalls. Large skeletons slouch in the ashen corners. A grunt echoes from the far end.

► **Skeletons.** Seven horses, died trapped in their stalls.

► **Grunt.** A shining black horse with a white skull head stands calmly in the last stall. Eats ash and pebbles. Acts like a normal horse. Friendly.

SKULL HORSE. *Shining black horse with a white skull head*

AC 7 [12], **HD** 2 (9 hp), **att** 2 × hoof (1d4), **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 240' (80'), **SV** D10 W11 P12 B13 S14, **ML** 8, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 20

► **Undead nature.** Does not sleep or breathe. Immune to poison and disease. Eats ash and pebbles.

6. Cages

Four iron cages sit under a canopy. Three are open and empty. An overgrown white hound stands in the fourth, staring at you, whining.

► **Iron cage.** Latched with a heavy hook, easy to shove open.

► **White hound.** Mutant. Will accept one new master, whoever pets it first.

MUTANT HOUND - *Rattle tail. Shark teeth. A third eye on the right side. Eats ash.*

AC 7 [12], **HD** 4* (18 hp), **att** 1 × bite (2d4 + bleed), **THACO** 16 [+3], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D10 W11 P12 B13 S14, **ML** 10, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 125

► **Bleed:** Loss of 1d3 damage per round until wounds are bandaged.

7. Armored cottage

The volcanic rock was recently cleared away from this large cottage. Pitted metal plates cover the windows. A light flickers inside. Smoke rises from the chimney.

► **Large cottage:** Living here is *Silvo*, 45, hairy, paranoid, survivalist. Blacksmith. Mutant crab-claw hand.

► **Thinks:** The party are ghosts, does not believe anyone is still alive, he is the last human.

► **Eats:** Oranges from the nearby white garden (p. 32).

► **Has** ugly black armor, giant cleaver, and chain whip.

► **Knows:** That Duchess Forza was at the height of her powers and genius. She was going to rule all the seven cities of the Sakeen Sea with her mighty sorcery. But there was a rift with Duke Avito. He was jealous of his wife. He surrounded himself with strange red robed priests and spent most of his time in private, starting a year ago.

SILVO THE SMITH

AC 3 [16] (black plate), **HD** 3 (13 hp), **att** 1 × cleaver (1d8+2), chain (2d4+2, 10' radius) **THACO** 17 [+2], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 10, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 35

SILVO'S ARMOR - This hulking black plate armor is immune to fire and lightning damage.

SILVO'S CLEAVER - This ugly weapon of patched steel has a vicious serrated edge that deals 1d8+2 damage. On an attack roll of 1, the cleaver shatters, damaging the wielder instead.

SILVO'S CHAIN - This rusty chain whip ends in an iron weight covered in razor blades. 10-foot reach, 2d4+2 damage. On an attack roll of 1, the chain wraps around the wielder and fuses solid: arm useless, user encumbered; chain must be destroyed.

8. White garden

Behind a **fence** of razor wire, twisted white **trees** curl over rows of sickly white **vines**. A lone white **bush** sits between the roots of one tree.

➤ **Fence.** A rough barricade of wires fixed to pig-iron posts. With a little time, one can carefully make an opening.

➤ **Trees.** Mutant blood-orange trees. No leaves, no bark. Produces and drops one orange each hour (rots away in d6 hours). Safe to eat, restores 1d6 hp. Rotting oranges litter the ground.

➤ **Vines.** White pumpkins filled with white worms. Take 1d6 damage if eaten.

➤ **Bush.** Mutant *Alma*, 25, sleepy, apathetic, bored. Gardener. Bone-white skin and hair, covered in white leaves. Can speak to plants. Very strong. Wants to stay.

▶ **Remembers:** Hearing an inhuman scream from atop the keep during the red storm.

ALMA

AC 5 [14], HD 2 (9 hp), att 1 × staff (1d6),

THACO 18 [+1], MV 120' (60'), SV D12 W13 P14
B15 S16, ML 11, AL NEUTRAL, XP 20

9. Shed

Inside this stone shed, three large **metal vats** sit half-full of dark, foul water. Heaps of cloth lie on a **long table**.

➤ **Metal vats.** Water, ash, algae, and rotting clothing. Foot-long red centipedes wriggle across the surface scum.

➤ **Long table.** Laundry in various stages of washing. Gray servant clothes, and black velvet suits and dresses.

RED CENTIPEDE

AC 7 [12], HD 1* (4 hp), Att 1 × bite (1d4 + poison),
THACO 19 [0], MV 60' (20'), SV D12 W13 P14 B15
S16, ML 7, AL Neutral, XP 13

▶ **Poison:** Causes victims to become horribly sick for ten days (save versus poison) — no physical activity possible except half speed movement.

10. Kitchen

Shining pots and pans hang from hooks in neat rows. The tile floor is spotless and the **pantry** is well stocked. Counters and stovetops gleam. A **man** snores on the floor.

➤ **Man.** *Durante*, 20, thin, long blonde hair, thin beard. Awkward, timid, giggles. (Long webbed green fingers.) Has been eating from the pantry, cleaning the kitchen.

▶ **Thinks:** You are Duke Avito / Duchess Forza. Serves you.

▶ **Knows:** That Duchess Forza was at the height of her powers and her genius. She was going to rule all the seven cities of the Sakeen Sea with her mighty sorcery. But there was a rift with Duke Avito. He was jealous of his wife. He surrounded himself with strange red robed priests and spent most of his time in private, starting a year ago.

DURANTE

AC 9 [10], HD 1 (4 hp), att 1 × dagger (1d4),

THACO 19 [0], MV 120' (60'), SV D12 W13 P14
B15 S16, ML 5, AL NEUTRAL, XP 10

➤ **Pantry.** Fruit preserves, dried fish, salted ox. If eaten, roll 1d10. On a 1, gain a mutation (1d4):

1. A snake's tongue
2. A termite's mandibles
3. A beetle's eyes
4. A small third arm

11. Burnt rooms

Ten identical small rooms line a dim hallway. Scorched remains of doors hang off melted hinges. Charred **corpses** lie on the beds and floors.

➤ **Corpses:** Dead servants. A woman clutches a singed letter: "*My darling Dafne, soon I'll have enough saved to take you away from this terrible place. Please don't despair! I promise you, we are just a few weeks away from starting a lifetime of joy together. Have faith. Love, Gianni*"

12. Main entrance

A pair of tall black doors bound in iron bars stand closed within a soaring gothic archway. Below the doors, a smoldering crack in the ground has damaged the stairs, and a large pale shape writhes in the scalding pit.

► **Doors.** Locked. Difficult to push open due to high standing water inside (total Strength of 50). Opens into the flooded foyer (p. 45). When opened, some of the water spills down the stairs and into the smoldering crack, boiling the ash louse to death.

► **Crack.** 10', encircles the entrance, crumbling ashen edges. Rippling waves of heat rise from the visible lava inside.

► **Pale shape.** Ash louse (p. 29), currently bathing in the lava, attacks anything that jumps over the crack.

13. Grassy hillside

To the west of the keep, hidden deep in the tall grass on a hillside, there stands a black iron hatch.

► **Hatch.** Locked (black iron key unlocks it — Standing tower, p. 34; Fallen light-house, p. 20; Encounters in the harbor, p. 12). Opens on a narrow tunnel that leads to a second locked black iron hatch (black iron key unlocks it), which opens out into the boiling cistern (p. 39).



INSIDE THE OBSIDIAN KEEP

Where is this place?

The inner keep where the nobility lived and entertained.

What is here?

Twisted rooms full of corpses, mostly.

Who is here?

Lovely horrors (p. 37), scavengers (p. 38), red priests (p. 37), Princess Viola (p. 47), doctor Miranda (p. 56), undead Duchess Forza (p. 63), dying Princess Bianca (p. 64), and the immortal horror Vermesh (p. 65).

What are Lovely Horrors?

Insane nobles with grotesque mutations on the face and body. Wear elegant clothing and white porcelain masks. Vacillate between haughty entitlement and bestial bloodlust.

What do they know?

Lovely horrors can converse, but they are also insane and ravenously hungry. Everyone knows Duchess Forza used her sorcery to destroy the warships, but then something went horribly wrong. They blame the craven Duke Avito, but they don't know what he did.

Everyone knows that, over the last year, Duke Avito has been spending all of his

time with the red priests, worshipping something called Vermesh. That's when the mutations started...

Note: *The red priests have no eyes, just skin. No sockets or lids or eyeballs, but they can see with psychic "spirit sight". They also have no left arm, but they do have an invisible "spirit" arm in its place.*

ARRIVAL

Unnatural storm clouds hang over the broken palace, casting it in deep shadows. A miserable cold rain falls on the broken walls and cracked roofs. Nearly every window is shattered, and most rooms appear dark.

The marble stairs warp, cant, and curl underfoot. The stone walls sag as though perpetually melting. Voices echo deep inside, punctuated by a rare inhuman laugh.

Note: *Two weeks ago this place was struck by a blast of Chaos energy, causing a "red storm" of devastating thunder and lightning, as well as mutations and madness, and the endless rainstorm over the Keep. The survivors are...quite strange.*



Encounters inside the Obsidian Keep

Roll 1d20 every two exploration turns.

- 1 A dark shape slithers through the standing water or under the sodden wallpaper.
- 2 Sounds of thousands of tiny creatures swarming inside the walls and ceiling.
- 3 Sounds of laughter and running feet in the distance.
- 4 The ceiling groans, bulges, and dumps a wave of filthy water.
- 5 d6 servant corpses, torn apart and fed upon.
- 6 d6 servant corpses, slowly reanimate as **chaos zombies**.
- 7 A dead **lovely horror** (silver brooch, porcelain mask, blue wig).
- 8 A drunk **lovely horror**, stumbling along, hungry and confused.
- 9 A **red priest**, dead (rapier stab wounds).
- 10 A **red priest** carving chaos runes into the wall.
- 11 A **red priest**, dying (claw marks), erupts into a visceral corruption.
- 12 A bloated, reeking soldier corpse full of **corpse flies**.
- 13 A dessicated soldier corpse covered in red worms.
(Chanting, merge into a **ravenous wyrm**ling).
- 14 The **motley magpie** somersaults down the corridor, ready for a fight! (Depending on reaction roll).
- 15 The **motley magpie** skitters across the ceiling, laughing.
- 16 Impacts strike a nearby wall, and a **visceral corruption** bursts through!
- 17 Three **ravenous wyrm**lings burrow along under the floor, visible in the gaps.
- 18 A dying **scavenger** crawls toward the party, gasping... the **motley magpie** yanks him back into a dark room!
- 19 Four **scavengers** carrying sacks full of trinkets glare from across the chamber...
- 20 The walls and floor twist, melt, and fuse into horrible organic shapes (chaos!)

CHAOS ZOMBIE - An undead human corpse covered in minor animal mutations.

AC 8 [11], **HD** 2* (9 hp), **Att** 2 x claws (1d4), **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 12, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 25

► **Chaotic Flesh:** Mutates when harmed (d6): 1 Feathers (doubles MV), 2 Scales (+2 AC), 3 Antlers (charge Att 1d6), 4 Extra arm (extra claw Att), 5-6 Talons or spikes (damage improves to d6).

► **Undead:** Immune to effects that affect living creatures (e.g. poison). Immune to mind-affecting or mind-reading spells (e.g. charm, hold, sleep).

CORPSE FLIES (swarm) - Almond-sized black flies with enlarged, vicious mandibles.

AC 7 [12], **HD** 3 (13 hp), **Att** 1 x swarm (2 or 4), **THACO** 17 [+2], **MV** 30' (10') / 60' (20') flying, **SV** D14 W15 P16 B17 S18, **ML** 11, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 35

► **Size:** 20' × 20' area, typically.

► **Immunity:** Only harmed by fire, sleep spells, smoke, or other area attacks.

► **Swarm attack:** Automatically damages characters within swarm area: 2hp if wearing armor, 4hp without. Attack by burrowing inside flesh.

► **Escaping:** On exiting the swarm, characters continue to suffer half damage until 1 full round is spent crushing the burrowed insects.

LOVELY HORROR - *An insane aristocrat with major animal mutations.*

AC 5 [14], **HD** 3* (13 hp), **Att** 2 × weapon (1d6) or seduce or mutate, **THACO** 17 [+2], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 9, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 50

► **Weapon:** Stiletto, claws, rapier, fangs.
► **Seduce:** Anyone who hears the lovely horror's voice must save versus spells or be seduced: defend, praise, and obey the lovely horror; unable to harm them. A character who saves is unaffected for the rest of the encounter.

► **Mutate:** The lovely horror chooses to grow more monstrous limbs (see below). 3-in-6 chance that this increases their damage to d8, then d10 and d12 on subsequent Mutate actions.

► **Mutations (d8):**

1. Falcon brown feathers, bronze beak, cruel talons 2. Crab red chitin, jagged claws, extra legs 3. Spider black hair, black eyes, extra legs 4. Shark gray fins, dead eyes, countless teeth 5. Beetle green chitin, iridescent wings, shining horns 6. Tiger striped fur, saber fangs, retractable claws 7. Unicorn silver horn, silver hooves, silver tail 8. Dragon curling horns, iron scales, adamant claws.

► **Noxious Perfume:** All creatures within 5' of a lovely horror must save vs poison or suffer a -2 penalty to damage rolls.

MOTLEY MAGPIE - *A skilled foreign assassin who succumbed to maddening bird-like mutations.*

AC 5 [14], **HD** 3 (13 hp), **Att** 2 × claw (1d6) or garrote, **THACO** 16 [+3], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 9, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 30

► **Garrote:** Target is choked. They cannot speak, move, or act. They take 1d6 damage (save vs death). The target continues to take 1d6 per round until they save or die. The assassin cannot move or attack other targets while doing this.

► **Acrobat:** When harmed, the assassin cartwheels 30' away and takes no damage (2/day).

► **Survivor:** When badly injured, the assassin tries to flee.

RAVENOUS WYRMLING - *A slimy human-sized red worm with lamprey teeth.*

AC 9 [10], **HD** 3* (13 hp), **Att** 1 × bite (1d10, slam) or thrash (1d8), **THACO** 14 [+5], **MV** 90' (30'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 50

► **Slam:** The wyrmling latches on to its prey, lifts it up, and slams it back down. Target falls prone and drops what they are holding (save vs death).

► **Thrash:** The wyrmling flails wildly, striking all targets within 10'.

► **Immunity:** Slimy flesh is immune to fire and lightning.

► **Slippery:** The wyrmling oozes slime. The ground next to it is always slippery (save vs paralysis to move).

RED PRIEST - *A human with no eye sockets and no left arm, but commands psychic powers.*

AC 5 [14] (hidden chainmail), **HD** 2** (9 hp), **Att** 1 × spirit claw (1d8), **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D11 W12 P14 B16 S15 (C2), **ML** 10, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 30

► **Immunity:** Mind-affecting or mind-reading spells (e.g. charm, hold, sleep).

► **Spirit Claw:** Target is numb and cannot act for one turn (save vs paralysis).

► **Spirit Eyes:** The priest can always see perfectly in any conditions.

► **Phantom Parry:** When the priest is hit by a melee attack, the damage is halved (3/day).

► **Phantom Grab:** When the priest is hit by a melee weapon, their spirit-arm grabs the weapon. Damage as normal but the weapon is unusable until the priest releases it or dies. The priest cannot Phantom Parry while grabbing a weapon (1/day).

► **Chaotic Death:** When a red priest dies, there is a 2-in-6 chance that the body erupts into a visceral corruption (see p.38).

SCAVENGER - A human with more greed than sense.

AC 5 [14] (breastplate), **HD** 1+1* (5hp), **Att** 1 x weapon (1d8), **THACO** 18 [+1], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 6, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 19

► **Weapon:** Short sword, hatchet, hammer, pickaxe, crossbow.

► **Grenado:** d8, blinding flash, ignites dry material, scatters loose material (1 each).

► **Desperado:** The scavenger must make a Morale check each time they are harmed. When they fail, the scavenger tries to flee, possibly by smashing through windows, doors, walls, and floors.

VISCERAL CORRUPTION - A human body exploded and inverted into a spider-shaped abomination.

AC 4 [15], **HD** 4* (18 hp), **Att** 2 x claw (1d8) or bile spray or sinew snare, **THACO** 16 [+3], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D10 W11 P12 B13 S14, **ML** 11, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 125

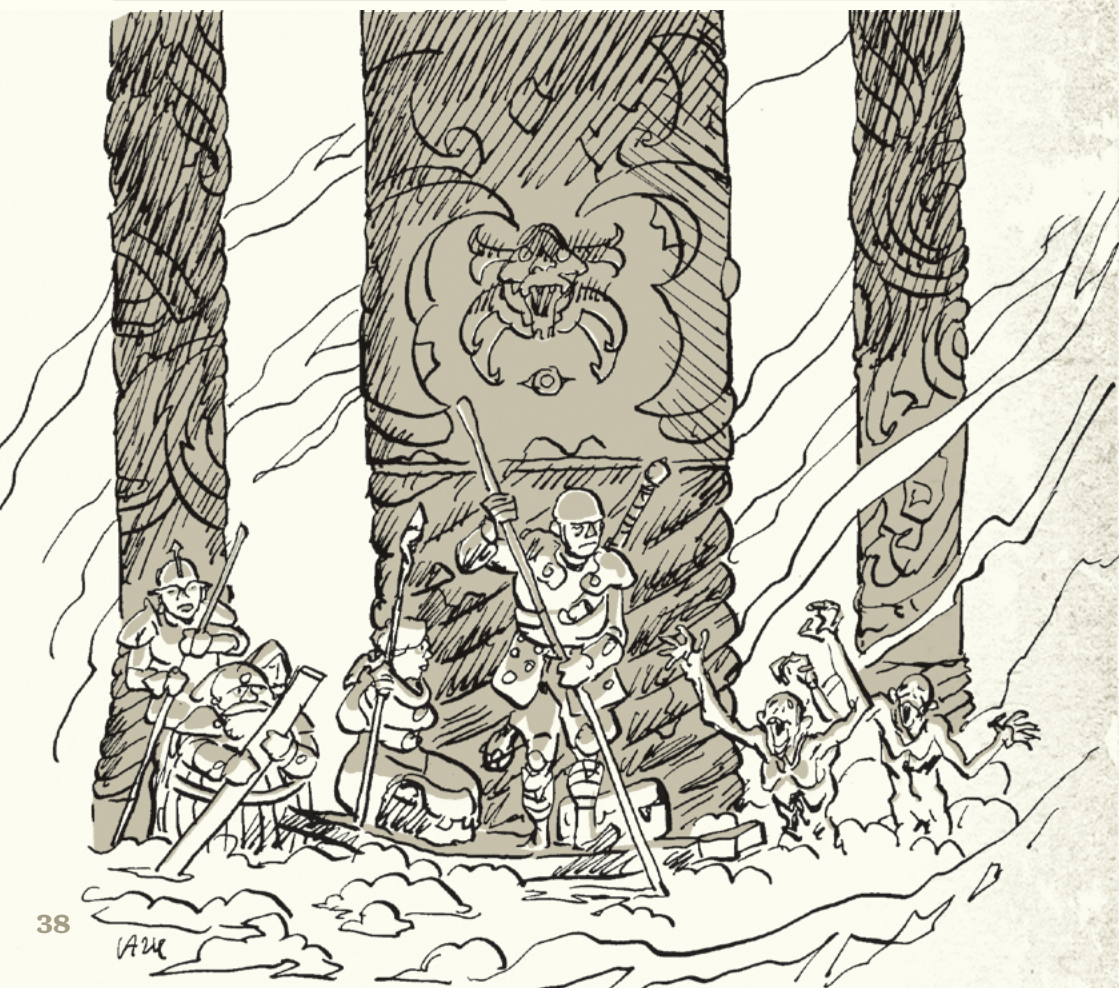
► **Bile Spray:** Stomach acid, 20' cone (d6).

► **Sinew Snare:** Ensnare one creature in a net of tendons (save vs paralysis). Target falls prone and cannot move or act until cut free.

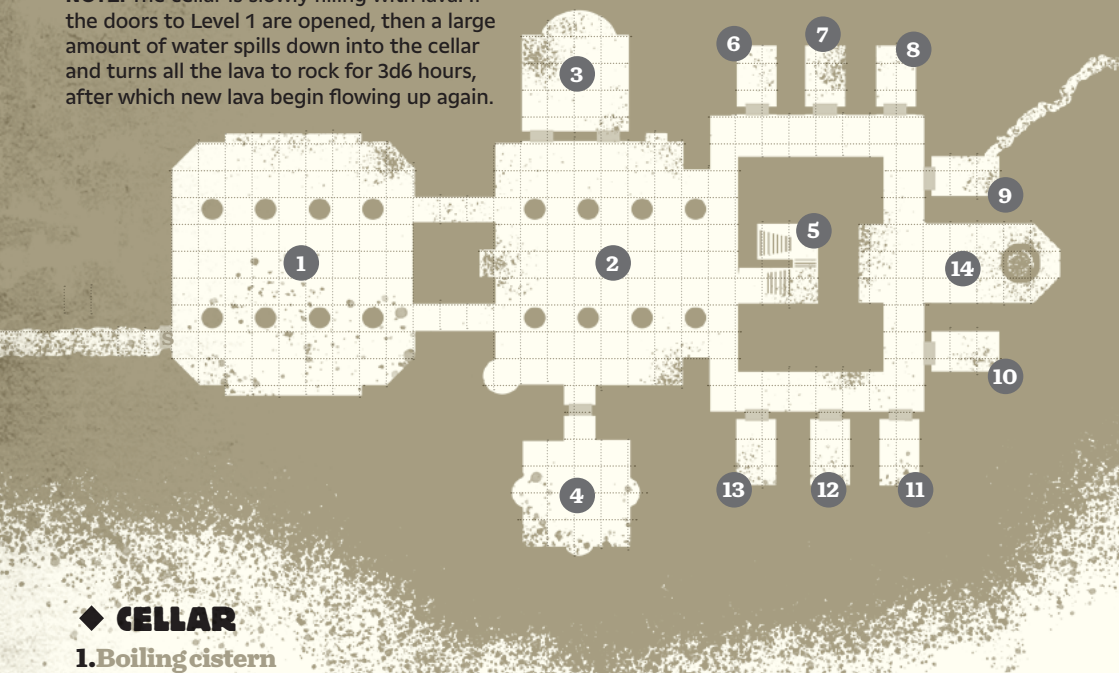
► **Horrific Aspect:** All who can see the visceral corruption must save vs paralysis or be too scared and nauseated to move or act for 1d4 rounds.

► **Inhuman Movement:** Climb on walls and ceilings.

► **Division:** Slicing or cutting attacks (swords, axes) cause the visceral corruption to tear itself apart. Each cutting attack creates a 2HD (9hp) visceral corruption with 1 claw attack.



NOTE. The cellar is slowly filling with lava. If the doors to Level 1 are opened, then a large amount of water spills down into the cellar and turns all the lava to rock for 3d6 hours, after which new lava begin flowing up again.



◆ CELLAR

1. Boiling cistern

This underground reservoir boils furiously, filling the air with scalding, blinding steam. A body lies face-down at the water's edge, a hint of gold on its neck.

► **Reservoir.** Waist-deep. 100x100 feet. Stone pillars, vaulted stone ceiling, brick floor. Obscured by bubbles and steam. Heated by approaching lava (d8 damage when touched – 1 damage per round for being in the water).

► **Hidden:** At the back of the chamber, under a layer of slimy muck, stands a locked black iron hatch (black iron key unlocks). Opens on a narrow tunnel that leads to a second locked black iron hatch (black iron key unlocks), which opens out of a Grassy Hillside to the west of the keep courtyard (p. 33).

► **Blinding steam.** Visibility zero. Fire is impossible here.

► **Body.** Male, sky blue uniform, bright red skin. Face has boiled away, leaving a clean white skull.

► **If touched:** He sits up and screams until his head tumbles off his neck.

1d6 chaos zombies (p. 36) animate each round until shut up or all 13 soldier and servant bodies in the water are animated.

► **Gold.** An officer's badge.

OFFICER BADGE - Immune to fear.

Command up to 10 humans within 120' to stop, flee, or be silent for 1 turn (1/day).

2. Blazing barracks

Huge stone pillars support this long vaulted chamber. A jagged chasm in the floor stretches the length of the room, oozing with red lava. Iron bunk beds and chests stand in scattered disarray, glowing red at their bases. Charred corpses lie everywhere.

Each turn, 3-in-6 chance that cinder shrimp (p. 29) emerge from the lava. Each turn, 2-in-6 chance that 2d6 corpses rise as chaos zombies (p. 36). Observant characters may notice movement under the surface before this happens.

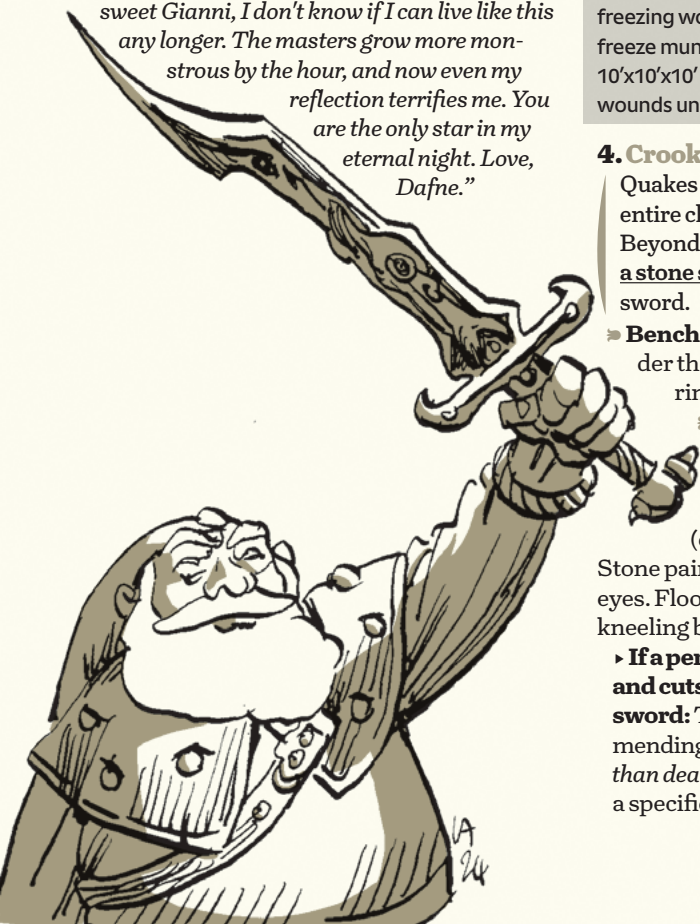
► **Stone pillars.** Each supports four torches in iron rings. The iron rings can each support the weight of one person.

- **Red lava.** Covers the entire floor (d8 damage when touched).
- **Heat.** After 1 turn, save vs death every minute or pass out.
- **Beds.** Sturdy for the next 1 turn (melting). Can support the weight of two people.
- **Chests.** Sturdy for the next 1 turn (melting). Can support the weight of one person. Each contains a sky blue soldier uniform, wool blanket, amulet of a militant angel (Gideon) or courageous saint (Eryn), empty satchel, burnt rations, (hot) dagger, melted soap, (hot) mirror, canteen of (hot) water, and a few salacious drawings.

➤ **Corpses.** Fifty soldiers, burnt sky blue uniforms, melted black armor. Died as they mustered, some bones rattle and shudder.

A charred hand clutches a singed letter: “my sweet Gianni, I don’t know if I can live like this any longer. The masters grow more mon-

strous by the hour, and now even my reflection terrifies me. You are the only star in my eternal night. Love, Dafne.”



3. Arctic armory

Glimmers of red light from the **lava** outside play on the floor, yet **ice crystals** hang in the air. Tall **wooden racks** cover the northern wall, where wicked **black-steel** weapons gleam in their cradles.

➤ **Lava.** Begins oozing into the room in 1 turn (d8 damage when touched).

➤ **Crystals.** The room is cold, breath mists (until the lava enters).

➤ **Wooden racks.** Bursts into flames when the lava enters.

➤ **Black-steel.** A rare starmetal alloy known as **nechrome**.

NECHROME WEAPONS - Two daggers, one Nechochrome rapier, one two-handed sword, one nechrome spear, ten nechrome arrows. Cause freezing wounds (1 per round until warmed), freeze mundane water on contact up to 10'x10'x10' (1/day - the weapon stops freezing wounds until dawn).

4. Crooked chapel

Quakes have shattered the floor, and the entire chamber leans sharply to one side. Beyond a cracked **wooden bench** stands a **stone statue** of a woman grasping a sword.

➤ **Bench.** For prayer and reflection. Under the seat is a braided silver wedding ring (25 GP).

➤ **Statue.** Saint Eryn, the Will to Live, patron of mothers and soldiers. Muscular, long hair, holding a sharp bronze sword (edges stained with old blood).

Stone painted: black hair, red skin, white eyes. Floor worn smooth (by soldiers kneeling before the saint).

➤ **If a person kneels before the statue and cuts their hand on the bronze sword:** The saint speaks in a stern commanding voice, “What do you fear more than death?” The person answers with a specific creature, person, effect, etc.

The saint replies, “*Rise now and go forth without fear.*” For d6 hours, the person has a +2 bonus to all rolls when near their stated fear, and then for the following d6 hours the person has a -2 penalty to all rolls when near their stated fear.

5. East stairs

Wide stone stairs spiral up from the dungeons to level 1. At the top of the stair is a solid **iron door**.

► **Door.** Locked (to keep prisoners downstairs). When the door is opened, a flood of cold filthy water pours down the stairs and into the **blazing barracks** (p. 39), where it cools the lava into solid rock and the air fills with scalding steam. In d6 hours, the lava begins flowing up through the cracks again.

6. Cell 1

Behind the locked iron bars of the small stone cell, a gaunt **hairy man** hangs from iron shackles on the back wall.

► **Man.** Percy (35), ex-stable boy. Bearded, filthy, starving. Shivers, weeps. Kind, honest. Locked up because Princess Bianca had a crush on him 20 years ago. If washed and shaved, he is still devastatingly gorgeous (no mutations).

► **Wants:** Freedom.

► **Fears:** Almost everything.

► **Secret:** Percy cannot be harmed by red priests or visceral corruptions (rare lawful blessing).

► **If freed:** Percy tends to wander away when not watched. Confused, defenseless.

PERCY - A confused and defenseless servant.

AC 9 [10], HD 1* (4 hp), Att 1 x fist (1d4),

THACO 19 [+0], MV 60' (20'), SV D12 W13 P14

B15 S16, ML 6, AL Lawful, XP 10

► **Blessed:** Percy cannot be attacked by red priests or visceral corruptions.

7. Cell 2

Behind the locked smoldering bars of the small stone cell, a sweaty young **man** clings to the wall above a crack in the floor that is slowly filling the cell with **incandescent lava**.

► **Lava.** Slowly covering the floor. Heat becoming unbearable. In d6 hours, Byron will pass out and fall to his doom. Each turn, there is a 3-in-6 chance that a swarm of **cinder shrimp** (p. 29) emerge.

► **Man.** Byron (30), charming thief from distant Vitela. Stained green coat, dark beard, tight trousers. Byron has a loop of red cord tied around his left wrist (the **crimson catgut**). Grins, jokes, winks. Locked up for trying to steal an amber orb (magical battery) from the Duchess Forza. Scheduled for execution.

► **Wants:** Freedom and luxury.

► **Fears:** Suffering and mutating.

► **If freed:** Byron follows the party until he sees a chance to escape the palace.

BYRON - A charming thief.

AC 6 [13], HD 2 (5 hp), Att 1 x weapon,

THACO 19 [+0], MV 60' (20'), SV D13 W14 P13

B16 S15, ML 9, AL Neutral, XP 25

► **Thief:** 2-in-6 chance to find and disarm traps, and to pick locks (4-in-6 with thieves' tools)..

CRIMSON CATGUT - The wearer is immune to disease, deafness, and blindness.

8. Cell 3

Behind the unlocked iron bars of the small stone cell, countless dark stained **bones** lie in a crooked heap. You hear a faint **buzzing** noise.

► **Bones.** Human skeletons, three women. Three skulls: eyes glow dimly, have arcane runes etched inside (“spirit” and “summon”).

► **If a rune skull is smashed:** Summons the ghost of an ancient witch, who answers one question correctly or performs one task (such as scout the

area or frighten someone nearby). The ghost witch cackles madly and anything near her is encrusted with blue frost.

► **Buzzing.** Under the bones nests a swarm of corpse flies (p. 36).

9. Cell 4

Behind the locked rusted bars of the small stone cell, a tattered gray sheet hangs from two nails on the back wall.

► **Gray sheet.** Obscures a narrow tunnel dug by escaped prisoners. Runs 100 feet, emerges onto a narrow rock ledge above a seaside cliff, 50 feet above waves crashing on sharp rocks. Two decaying corpses lie mangled on the rocks below. A seagull sits on the rock ledge.

► **Seagull.** A sapphire ring glitters on its leg. Any sudden move scares the seagull away.

SAPPHIRE RING - Seagull form. Anyone who puts on the ring turns into a seagull until the ring is removed. When the ring is removed from the current seagull, it reverts to an elderly woman named Gertrid who has no memory of anything useful, but knows many bread recipes.

10. Cell 5

Behind the mangled iron bars of the small stone cell, a white weasel nurses two tiny white weasel kittens in a nest of yellow bones.

► **Iron bars.** Twisted by a partially collapsed ceiling. Disturb the bars and stone blocks fall (2d6 damage, save vs paralysis for half damage).

► **Weasel.** Proud mother. Hissy, protective. Becomes loyal to the first person who feeds her. Can hunt and kill any creature smaller than a cat in mere seconds.

► **Kittens.** Mewling, adorable, nippy. Become loyal to the first person who feeds them.

► **Bones.** Human. Covered in tiny tooth marks (prisoner devoured by the weasel).

WHITE WEASEL

AC 6 [13], HD 1-1*(3 hp), Att 1 × bite (1d3 + blood sucking), THAC0 19 [0], MV 120' (40'), SV D14 W15 P16 B17 S18, ML 7, AL Neutral, XP 6

► **Infravision:** 30'.

► **Blood sucking:** Upon a successful attack, locks onto the victim and drains its blood: 1d4 automatic damage per round.

Detaching: If weasel or victim dies.

11. Cell 6

Behind the locked iron bars of the small stone cell, a metal man stands motionless, gazing with glowing blue eyes. A fist-sized blue crystal is embedded in his chest.

► **Metal man.** Vertex (900), Ghiran machine priest. Slender, rusty, blue robe. Gentle, timid.

► **Wants:** To preach logic, mathematics, and law.



► **If freed:** Vertex follows the party fearfully, but has a 3-in-6 chance of fleeing in a random direction at the sight of chaos mutations.

► **Blue crystal.** The **Soulstone**. Keeps Vertex alive. Easily retrieved with a dagger or sharp object.

VERTEX - A gentle mechanical priest.

AC 2 [17], **HD** 3 (13 hp), **Att** 1 x metal fist (1d6), **THACO** 17 [+2], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 10, **AL** Lawful, **XP** 35

► **Encyclopedic:** Able to identify any natural creature or phenomenon on sight.

► **Phobia:** 3-in-6 chance of fleeing at the sight of Chaos mutations (or lovely horrors).

SOULSTONE - Bearer has 18 Intelligence, 4-in-6 chance to identify any natural creature or phenomenon on sight, or to know one fact about any historical event. They also become phobic of chaos.

12. Cell 7

Behind the locked iron bars of the small stone cell, a **woman** hangs from a bar on the ceiling, doing pull-ups with one arm.

► **Woman.** *Helena* (25), ducal soldier. Tall, muscular, sky blue uniform. Impatient, brutal. Mutated vulture talon hand. Locked up for brawling.

► **Wants:** To fight “red-robed freaks”.

► **Bad at:** loyalty and stealth.

► **If freed:** Helena quickly runs off to fight cultists and lovely horrors on her own. 3-in-6 chance she gets herself killed.

HELENA - A powerful brawler and soldier.

AC 4 [15], **HD** 3 (13 hp), **Att** 2 x weapon (1d8), **THACO** 17 [+2], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 11, **AL** Lawful, **XP** 35

► **Phobia:** Insects.

► **Hatred:** Attacks lovely horrors on sight.

13. Cell 8

Behind the locked iron bars of the small stone cell, a **woman** in a sparkling violet gown reclines on a black silk loveseat, holding a black lace fan to obscure her face.

► **Woman.** *Baronness Oklavia* (45), local aristocrat (**lovely horror**, p. 37). Lace, jewels (500 gp), predatory eyes. Silver beetle brooch. Seductive, playful, mocking. Locked up for joking about the Duke’s “private pursuits in the attic”.

► **Wants:** To laugh at others’ suffering, and drink.

► **Fears:** Being laughed at.

► **Owns:** A blue pearl key (**Blue pearl door**, p. 50)

► **Secret:** Her mouth has mutated into four grotesque insect mandibles, yet her voice remains sultry and compelling. Her kisses are terrifying.

► **If freed:** Oklavia goes to the **banquet hall** (p. 47) and starts drinking. Lovely horrors do not attack the party while she is nearby. When drunk, she forgets who the adventurers are and acts as a standard lovely horror.

14. Black pit

This **rocky hole** plunges straight down into utter darkness. In the inky shadows, two **red pinpricks** of light slowly blink.

► **Rocky hole.** Ten feet across, 50 feet deep. Lava reaches the hole in 1 hour.

► **Pinpricks.** A pair of red eyes. A gray-skinned woman without legs. *Pavnutia* (2,200), vampire alchemist from space (currently powerless). Red eyes, gray skin, black hair. Filthy golden **silk dress**. Legs chopped off and canine teeth extracted (by Duchess Forza). Gaunt, weak, blood-starved. Scientific genius, professional exsanguinator.

► **Wants:** Human blood, and to return to the orbital vampire city of Araveshti.

► **Fears:** Sunlight.

► **Can identify:** Any chemical or mechanical object or phenomena on sight.

► **Can read:** Any language. Currently harmless, must be carried.

► **If fed human blood:** Pavnutia quickly regrows her legs and teeth, and regains her full strength and magical abilities (after dealing 15 damage or draining 3 human sized bodies). She slaughters the nobility in the palace, then establishes herself as the Duchess of Night. She will need loyal vassals...

VAMPIRE'S DRESS - Woven of cosmoth silk, grants immunity to light-based dangers (sunlight, radiant beams, etc.).



PAVNUTIA, VAMPIRE: An immortal blood-sucking alchemist from outer space.

AC 2 [17], **HD** 9** (40 hp), **Att** 2 × bite (1d10, drink) or claw (2d6) or by weapon, **THAC0** 18 [+1], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D8 W9 P10 B10 S12, **ML** 9, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 2,300

► **Immunity.** Non-magical weapons.

► **Weakness.** Silver weapons (2x damage).

► **Drink.** The vampire gains hp equal to half the damage.

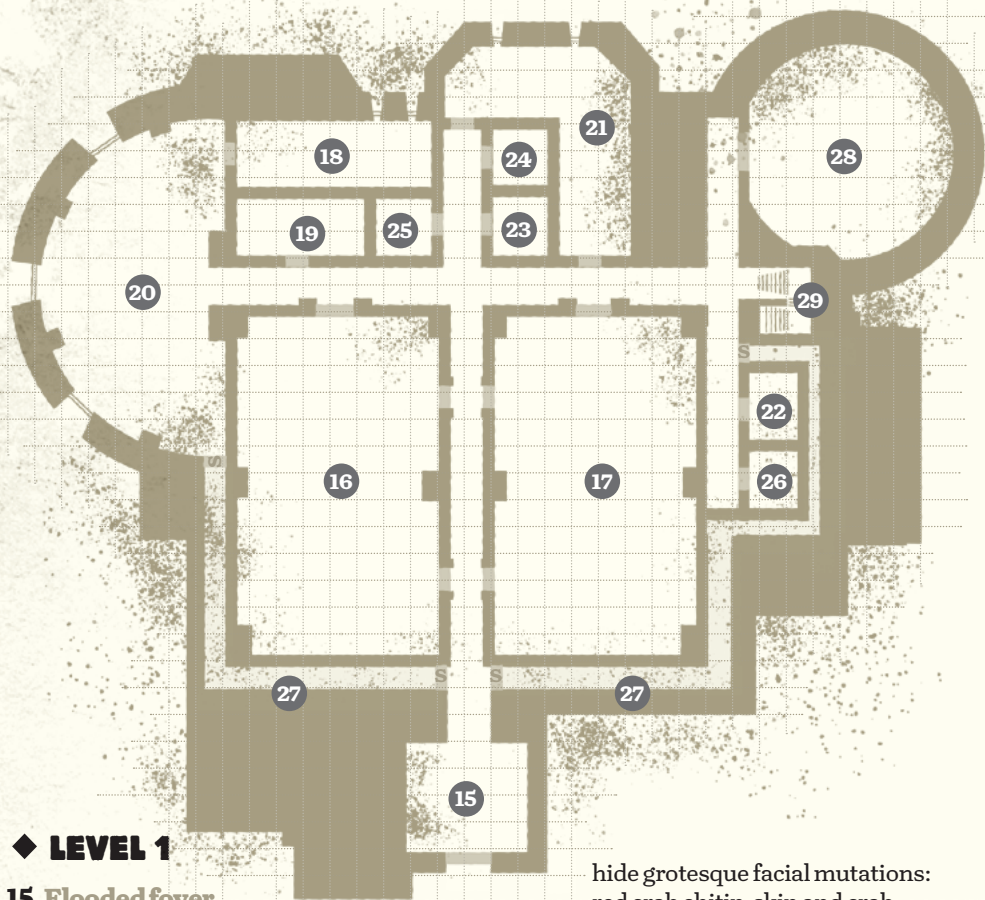
► **Block and disarm.** When hit by a weapon, the vampire deftly grasps the weapon and takes no damage (2/day).

► **Shadow Dance.** When missed by an attack, the vampire vanishes and reappears up to 20' away.

► **Daggers Galore.** All targets within 10' take 3 damage.

► **Mourning Breath.** The vampire exhales an alchemical cloud. Targets within 10' save vs breath or take 1d6 damage and are blinded and deafened by their own trickling blood (2/day).





◆ LEVEL 1

15. Flooded foyer

Cold murky **water** covers the marble floor of the black marble entrance hall. Cold water drips from the cracked ceiling. Tattered **tapestries** drip and sag on the walls. Two crumpled **corpses** lie huddled together in the corner.

► **Water.** Knee-deep, stagnant, full of ash. Hides coins scattered across the floor (287 GP, dropped by fleeing people). If lightning strikes, creatures in the water take d6 damage.

► **Tapestries.** Sky blue silk, black crests (noble families): falcon, crab, spider, shark, beetle, tiger, unicorn, dragon.

► **Corpses.** Thunder-crushed and covered in white **residue**. Tattered violet velvet garments, silver crab brooches (2 × 100 GP). Cracked white porcelain masks

hide grotesque facial mutations: red crab chitin-skin and crab

eye-stalks.

► **Residue.** Insect eggs: When the corpses are disturbed, a swarm of **corpse flies** (p.36) burst out of their mouths.

16. Drowned ballroom

Shattered **windows** gape all around the echoing ballroom. **Water** ripples darkly on black marble tiles. Massive crystal **chandeliers** shaped like human hands creak in the wind. Twisted wooden **objects** litter the floor amidst a carpet of still corpses. Three bent **figures** shuffle through the carnage.

• **Note:** *A waltz was in progress when the red storm began, and everyone was struck by lightning.*

► **Windows.** Stone walls for 10', and then shattered window frames for 20'. Exposed to the elements. Windy, wet, cold.



➤ **Water.** Ankle-deep, full of old blood and bile. If lightning strikes, creatures in the water take d6 damage.

➤ **Chandeliers.** Loud sounds (screams) make them shatter and fall (save vs breath or take d6 damage).

➤ **Objects.** Cellos and violins warped to look like people in pain. Scream when touched.

➤ **Corpses.** Men and women, burned and covered in red worms. Violet velvet suits and dresses, white frill collars, blue wigs, white porcelain masks. All mutated with various claws, scales, feathers, mandibles, and insect eyes. Every turn, 2-in-6 chance of a random body rising as a chaos zombie (p. 36) and 2-in-6 chance of a random body vomiting a swarm of corpse flies (p. 36).

➤ **Worms.** Inching, nibbling. Whispering “Ver...mesh... Ver...mesh...” When harmed, the worms swarm together in 1d4 rounds to form a ravenous wyrmling (p. 37).

➤ **Figures.** Three lovely horrors (p. 37). Same as the corpses, but upright. Looting the dead for jewelry.

▶ **Want:** Servants and luxury.

▶ **Fear:** Poverty and work.

▶ **Hate:** The red priests and Duke Avito (filthy, obsessive).

▶ **Love:** Duchess Forza (gorgeous, powerful).

▶ **Prone:** To violent tantrums.

▶ **Items:** Blue pearl key (blue pearl door, p. 47), four blue pearl necklaces (200 GP), three silver family brooches (100 GP).

17. Banquet hall

Black marble buttresses shaped like human teeth arch over a long granite dining table covered in smashed dishes. Mist and rain blow in through the shattered windows to mingle with the water on the floor. A lone figure stands by a dark fireplace, staring at a body.

• **Note:** During the red storm, Viola told her younger brother Orince Orsino to save the servants while she fought the red priests that corrupted their father, Duke Avito.

➤ **Dishes.** Place settings for a hundred guests. Cracked plates, smashed glasses (thunder). Scattered platters of rotten fish (flopping weakly) and slimy fowl (crawling weakly) covered in wriggling red worms.

➤ **Worms.** Inching, nibbling. Whispering “Ver...mesh... Ver...mesh...” when harmed, the worms swarm together in 1d4 rounds to form a ravenous wyrmling (p. 37).

➤ **Water.** Ankle-deep, full of old blood and bile. If lightning strikes, creatures in the water take d6 damage.

➤ **Figure.** Princess Viola (30), eldest sister. Curling blue hair, tattered black dress, white frill collar, silver circlet. Miserable, shocked. Normally cunning, commanding. Her clear glass skin reveals her muscles, skull, and eyes. Tiny red worms wriggle through her visible viscera.

▶ **Wants:** All red priests dead.

▶ **Fears:** For her sister Bianca and brother Orsino.

▶ **Asks:** “Where is my brother, Orsino? Did he save the servants? Did he escape?”

“Where is my sister Bianca? I can’t find her anywhere!”

▶ **Demands:** “You must kill the red priests, this is all their fault!”

▶ **Attacks:** Anyone wearing Orsino’s circlet in a blind rage.

➤ **Fireplace.** Large, cold, wet. Can be climbed to access the tiger suite (p. 35) and Duke Avito’s room (p. 63).

➤ **Body.** Dead (rapier stab wounds). A pale woman with unnaturally wrinkled skin in a red robe. The dead red priestess has no eyes and no left arm (magically consumed by Vermesh).

▶ **Item:** amulet of Vermesh (300 GP).



PRINCESS VIOLA - A noble leader, lightning fast duellist, and mutation victim.

AC 3 [16] (lightning fast), **HD** 4 (4 hp), **att** 4 x rapier (1d8), **THACO** 14 [+5], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 11, **AL** Lawful, **XP** 125

► **Glass cannon:** Her fragile skin shatters at 0 hp and she expires (4 is her max hp total.)

► **Infested:** When she dies, her tiny worms burst out to form 3 **ravenous wyrmlings**.

► **Items:** Viola's silver rapier (250 GP). **Viola's silver circlet** with black pearls (1,000 GP). White iron key

VIOLA'S CIRCLET.

► **When placed in its case in Princess Viola's room** (p. 62), it summons a sylph (tiny brown six winged warrior, intelligent but does not speak), which protects whoever last touched Viola's circlet from tiny creatures (insects, rats, etc.) for 1d6 hours 1/day.

► **While worn:**

- Gain +1 DEX.

- Disables the trap at the door of Bianca's room.

18. Rippling gallery

Rain blows in steadily from the shattered windows, making a score of huge oil **paintings** drip and **smear**. Light reflects off the standing **water**, casting ripples on the walls. Dark bronze **sculptures** loom in the center of the room. A **person** lies trapped under the center sculpture, twitching and gasping.

► **Rain.** Cold, clean.

► **Paintings.** Damaged. Set in golden **frames**. Twenty portraits of elegant ladies and proud men in ornate aristocratic costumes. Looks like they are screaming and weeping.

► **Smear:** When approached within 10', the painted figures lunge out to smother faces with thick oozing oil. Targets must save vs paralysis or be blinded and begin suffocating (1d4 per round). Effect ceases when out of reach of the paintings (20').

► **Frames.** 20 of them. Enormous (20 lbs or 200 coins) and fabulously baroque (250 GP).

► **Water.** Knee-deep, full of oil (when ignited, the water burns for 1d6 turns). If lightning strikes, creatures in the water take d6 damage

► **Sculptures.** Five nude athletes wrestling giant beasts: wolf, stag, ape, peacock, tortoise. Extremely heavy (500 lbs or 5,000 coins) but worth 7,500 GP.

► **Person.** **Yorick** (30), servant. Sodden smock, thin beard, blotches of bronze on his skin. Shivering, starving, desperate. During the red storm, he hid under the bronze peacock's tail, but his left arm fused into the bronze and now he cannot escape. When the water level rises, he drowns.

► **Wants:** To live.

► **Knows:** Ten years ago he helped Duchess Forza open an ancient tomb where she got something important (**stone arch**, p. 25).

YORICK - a palace servant and mutation victim.

AC 9 [10], **HD** 1 (4 hp), **att** 1 x weapon (1d6), **THACO** 19 [+0], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 7, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 25

► **Death:** when he dies, Yorick immediately becomes a **chaos zombie** (p. 36)

19. Sodden library

Cracked mahogany bookshelves stand empty along the walls. Thousands of torn **pages** and **covers** lie in a sodden **heap**, rising high above the **standing water**. Glistening black **spatters** on the walls trickle and swirl, defying gravity. Two **servants** bend over a figure in red, struggling quietly and whispering angrily.

► **Pages.** Ancient parchment, decaying. All blank.

► **Covers.** Rotting leather, silver wire inlays. Titles indicate books about history, philosophy, music, and art.

► **Heap.** Waist-high. Searching reveals scroll of *read languages*, *floating disc* and *read magic*.

► **Water.** Knee-deep, full of ink. If lightning

strikes, creatures in the water take d6 damage.

➤ **Spatters.** Living ink (escaped from books).

Communicates by drawing pictures on walls.

▶ **Wants:** To escape the palace.

▶ **Fears:** Water (dilutes, washes away).

▶ **Asks:** To be carried away safely in a dry book or bottle.

▶ **If helped:** The ink proves loyal and has a 2-in-6 chance of answering any question about the red priests, Duke Avito, or Duchess Forza.

▶ **If denied:** Attacks.

LIVING INK - *Sentient liquid ink.*

AC 6 [13], **HD** 4 (18 hp), **Att** 3 x smother (1d10), **THACO** 12 [+7], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D10 W11 P12 B13 S14, **ML** 10, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 200

▶ **Size:** 10' × 10' blob.

▶ **Ooze:** Can move on walls and ceilings, and through tiny gaps.

➤ **Servants.** *Gio* and *Irma* (55), **serfs.** Filthy tattered smocks and tunics. Gaunt, pale. Minor mutations (gull feathers, leathery skin). Enraged, desperate. Beating the red priest, demanding that he cure their mutations (they just found him a moment ago).

SERF: *a palace servant and mutation victim.*

AC 9 [10], **HD** 1 (4 hp), **att** 1 x fist (1d4), **THACO** 19 [+0], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 6, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 10

➤ **Figure.** *Uther* (50), **red priest** (p. 40). Pale, unnaturally wrinkled skin, red robe. No eyes, no left arm (magically consumed by Vermesh). Fanatical, secretive. Was asleep, now being violently awakened. About to attack (slaughter) the servants.

▶ **Wants:** To gaze upon vermeh ("They are summoned, they are near!").

▶ **Fears:** Being killed by Princess Viola (has been sneaking and hiding).

▶ **Has:** Amulet of Vermesh (300 gp), **silver tome.**

THE SILVER BOOK OF HANNUVIEL - *Legendary tales of Lawful saints and heroes. Contains the only written record of the road to Carrion Vale and the last known location of the Golden Skull of Saint Anarak (legendary relic). Book bearer is immune to charms and can detect lies for 1 turn (1/week).*

20. Scorched solarium

Soaring oval windows stand cracked into dozens of jagged shifting **panes**.

Scorchmarks slice across the walls at wild angles. **Burnt pieces** of tables and chairs bob in the **standing water**. Beside a glittering golden **globe**, a **body** lies on a fainting couch, breathing wetly.

➤ **Panes.** Each turn, a pane of glass shifts in the wind and a blinding flash of light refracts through the room. 2-in-6 chance the light is a scorching beam that cuts across the room, burning walls, furniture, and creatures. Targets must save vs breath or suffer d6 damage. When the windows shatter away, the beams stop.

➤ **Scorchmarks.** Made by light beams through the broken windows.

➤ **Burnt pieces.** Burned by light beams through the broken windows.

➤ **Water.** Knee-deep, full of splinters. If lightning strikes, creatures in the water take d6 damage.

➤ **Globe.** Gold shell, silver outlines, ruby cities (30lbs or 300 coins, 1,000 GP). Locked. Contains three bottles of the rare enchanting Dorona wine (drinkers are highly suggestible, also highly flammable, 500 GP).

➤ **Body.** Woman (prone) in a violet dress, white frill collar, blue wig (bald), white porcelain mask. Scared, confused, cannot move. Strange, **jelly-like** tremors going across her body.

▶ **Mutters:** "The duchess will save me... just need to wait here, and the Duchess will save me..."

▶ **Jelly-like:** woman has mutated into a sticky ooze. If touched, she sticks and tries to engulf. Victim takes 1d4 damage per round. Requires fire or acid to dissolve and escape (10 damage total, possibly harming victim).

21. Menagerie

This long stone-tiled walkway passes by several wrought-iron cages, each slightly bent and twisted. In each cage, a creature huddles in the shadows. A body in red lies on the path.

➤ **Cages.** 10' x 10'. Thunder-damaged. Bars bent, doors weakened. Each creature has a 1-in-6 chance of escaping each turn.

▶ **Cage 1:** Aellope (ancient), bitter harpy. Human-sized black vulture with a cruel woman's face. Foul offal on the floor (rotten). **Wants** freedom, meat, and revenge against Duchess Forza for imprisoning her. **Fears** nothing. Confident liar, vicious killer.

▶ **Cage 2:** Phoenix (ancient), fire-bird. Hawk-sized bird, sparkling red and gold feathers. Ash on the floor (hot). **Wants** freedom. **Fears** water. Speaks like a wise old man. **Willing** to be a loyal companion.

▶ **Cage 3:** Ligeia (ancient), siren. Beautiful woman with long fish tail. Sullen, depressed. **Refuses** to sing. **Wants** freedom, and water. **If freed**, requires help to reach the sea. **If returned to the sea**, Ligeia sings one piercing note that reduces all lovely horrors to half hit points for the rest of the day. Her 500 fish scales are worth 25 GP each, an alchemist can make potions of water-breathing, water-walking, or enchanting singing from them.

▶ **Cage 4:** Galini (young), wingless blue dragon. Cat-sized, violet scales, deer antlers. Playful, desperate for affection. **Speaks** like a shy little girl. **Willing** to be a loyal companion.

▶ **Cage 5:** Sharlo (young), orb weaver spider. Head-sized, blue fur, white eyes. Clever, devious. Quickly writes simple messages in thick white webbing: "*Hello. Friend. Help. Gold.*" **Wants** freedom, and bodily fluids. **Claims** to be loyal,

betrays the party as soon as no one is looking.

▶ **Cage 6:** Krios (elderly), rubbish sphinx. Small white goat with stunted white wings and the head of an old man. Coughs, stammers, shivers. **Tries** to tell riddles, but always gets confused and trails off in the middle. Sneezes foul, freezing globules. Harmless, pathetic.

➤ **Body in red.** Dead (rapier stab wounds). A pale woman with unnaturally wrinkled skin in a red robe. She has no eyes and no left arm (magically consumed by Vermesh). **Wears** amulet of Vermesh (300 GP). Covered in tiny red worms (eating the flesh).

➤ **Worms.** Inching, nibbling. Whispering "*Ver...mesh... ver...mesh...*" When harmed, the worms swarm together to form a ravenous wyrmling (p. 37).

ANCIENT BITTER HARPY (AELOPPE)

an enlarged vulture with the head of an elderly human woman.

AC 7 [12], **HD** 3* (13 hp), **Att** 2 x claw (1d4), 1x song (deceive), **THACO** 17 [+2], **MV** 60' (20') / 150' (50') flying, **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 7, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 50

▶ **Deceive:** Anyone who hears the harpy's song must save versus spells or be deceived: believe whatever the harpy says, obey the harpy, unable to harm the harpy. A character who saves is unaffected for the rest of the encounter.

ANCIENT FIRE-BIRD (PHOENIX)

Small birds of prey with flaming wingtips.

AC 8 [11], **HD** 1/2* (2 hp), **ATT** 1 x talons or beak (1d2 + 1d2 fire), **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 480' (160') flying, **SV** D14 W15 P16 B17 S18 (NH), **ML** 8, **AL** Lawful, **XP** 6

▶ **Revive:** Revives from its own ashes when killed – will leave if this ability is abused by its master

▶ **Immunity:** Fire, poison.

ANCIENT SIREN (LIGIEA) - Beautiful aquatic humanoids with fish tails in place of legs.

AC 6 [13], **HD** 1 (4 hp), **Att** 1 × weapon (1d6 or by weapon), **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16 (1), **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 10

► **Song:** Reduces all lovely horrors to half hp for the rest of the day.

YOUNG WINGLESS BLUE DRAGON (GALINI)

Cat-sized sinuous lizard with blue and violet scales.

AC 5 [14], **HD** 1* (4 hp), **Att** 2 x claw (1d2), 1 × bite (1d3) or breath, **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16 (1), **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 13

► **Breath:** 20' long line of acid. All caught in the area suffer damage equal to the dragon's current hit points, save versus breath for half (3/day).

YOUNG ORB WEAVER SPIDER (SHARLO)

Head sized spider, blue fur, white eyes.

AC 7 [12], **HD** 1* (4 hp), **Att** 4 x claw (1d2), or orb web, **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16 (1), **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 13

► **Orb web:** Spits a ball of webbing up to 12'. Target must save vs breath or be unable to move or act for one round.

ELDERLY RUBBISH SPHINX (KRIOS) - Small white goat with stunted white wings and the head of an old man.

AC 9 [10], **HD** 1* (4 hp), **Att** 1 x freezing globule, **THACO** 19 [0], **MV** 60' (20'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16 (1), **ML** 8, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 13

► **Freezing globule:** Range 12', 1d4 cold damage.

22. Blue pearl door

This large circular **door** gleams with dozens of blue **pearls** set into a black iron sculpture of dancing nobles.

► **Door.** Requires a **blue pearl key** (South gate, p. 30; Cell 8, p. 43; Black pit, p. 43; Council chamber, p. 51). Difficult to pick. Light scorchmarks on the floor and walls around. Faint smell of ozone. Barely audible humming sound.

► **Enchanted.** Opening the door without a blue pearl key triggers white lightning, 2d6 damage to all within 10 feet.

► **Pearls.** Rare, difficult to remove without damaging (requires 1 hour and a Dexterity check to remove 3d6 pearls intact). 60 In total, 100 GP each.

► **Inside.** The false vault. Silver floor tiles, 90 small ebony shelves. Each contains a hand-sized ebony box lined with violet velvet displaying a fist-sized **sapphire**.

► **Sapphire.** Each gem is actually a hibernating flesh-eating **sapphire scarab**. When removed from the vault, they awaken in 1 turn and attack the thieves as a swarm.

SAPPHIRE SCARABS (swarm) - A palm-sized beetle with razor-edged sparkling blue wings.

AC 7 [12], **HD** 4 (18 hp), **Att** 1 x swarm (3 or 6), **THACO** 16 [+3], **MV** 30' (10') / 60' (20') flying, **SV** D14 W15 P16 B17 S18 (NH), **ML** 11, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 75

► **Size:** 20' × 20' area, typically.

► **Swarm attack:** Automatically damages characters within swarm area: 2 hp if wearing armour, 4 hp without. Attack by slicing with razor-like mandibles and wings, wounds do not clot, prey bleeds to death.

► **Escaping:** On exiting the swarm, characters continue to suffer half damage until 1 full round is spent binding their bleeding wounds.

► **Immunity:** Immune to heat and cold. Only harmed by sleep spells.

23. Cleaning closet

Danger. 1-in-6 chance of a lovely horror (p. 37) sitting alone, humming a nursery rhyme.

This small chamber is lined with simple wooden shelves and bins.

- **Small chamber.** Large enough to fit several people, crowded together.
- **Shelves and bins.** Mops, buckets, brooms, soap, brushes, sponges, oil, rags.

24. Lighting closet

Danger. 1-in-6 chance of a lovely horror (p. 37) gnawing on a dead servant.

This small chamber is lined with simple wooden shelves and bins.

- **Small chamber.** Large enough to fit several people, crowded together.
- **Shelves and bins.** Lanterns, oil, candles, matches, wicks, snuffers, rags.

25. Coat closet

Danger. 1-in-6 chance of a lovely horror (p. 37) neatly piling dead rats.

This small chamber is lined with simple wooden shelves and bins.

- **Small chamber.** Large enough to fit several people, crowded together.
- **Shelves and bins.** Fur coats, rain coats, rain boots, velvet cloaks, sun hats, tricornes.

26. Tool closet

Danger. 1-in-6 chance of a lovely horror (p. 37) quietly lecturing an assembly of red maggots.

This small chamber is lined with simple wooden shelves and bins.

- **Small chamber.** Large enough to fit several people, crowded together.
- **Shelves and bins.** Hammers, nails, saws, paint, oil, chisel, twine, rope, ladder, rags.

27. Servant passages

Danger. 2-in-6 chance of d\$ chaos zombizq (p. 36).

These narrow access corridors (inside the walls) only allow movement in single file. The walls are cracked and sagging. Water drips from the ceiling. Floorboards creak and bend.

- **Walls.** Thunder-damaged, neglected. Splintered wood, rotting plaster. Every few paces, a wall bulges into the passageway.
- **Floorboards.** 1-in-6 chance of a foot falling through and being stuck for 1 turn (Strength check to escape).
- **Bulges.** Terrified servants fused into the walls (wood and plaster). One weakly kicking leg, one feebly clawing arm, one wildly darting eye, mouths wide in silent wails. Dying slowly. Almost impossible to help.

28. Council chamber

A massive circular table dominates this windowless circular room, flanked by small desks and countless chairs. Loose papers float in the standing water. Three small wooden boxes sit on the table's edge. Two masked men in dark suits hurl insults at each other.

- **Men.** Lovely horrors (p. 37), petty nobles. One has moth eyes and antenna (*Sir Tybalt*), and the other has green leathery iguana flesh (*Sir Valentine*). Violet velvet suits, blue wigs, white frills, silver brooches (100 GP). Soaked, tattered, filthy. Enraged, self-righteous, cruel. Throwing ink wells and paper weights at each other.

► **Shouting at each other:**

- "This is all your fault, you witless fool!"
- "You're the one who refused to speak up!"
- "You killed my favorite hound!"
- "You killed my favorite wife!"

► **Wants:** Pity and admiration.

► **Fears:** Responsibility and consequences.

► **Knows:** That Duchess Forza is up in her suite.

- **Table.** 15 feet across. A large detailed wooden sculpture of Isla Requia and the

Obsidian Keep. Labels and markings for administration and military planning.

► **Secret:** a button on the miniature light-house opens a hidden drawer containing 20 scorpion oil cigars (hallucinogenic, 1,000 GP) and a **blue pearl key**. Under the table is a **body in red**.

► **Body in red.** Dead (rapier stab wounds). A pale man with unnaturally wrinkled skin in a red robe. He has no eyes and no left arm (magically consumed by Vermesh). **Wears:** amulet of Vermesh (300 gp). Covered in tiny red **worms** (eating the flesh).

► **Worms.** Inching, nibbling. Whispering “Ver...mesh... Ver...mesh...” When harmed, the worms swarm together to form a **ravenous wyrmling** (p. 37).

► **Desks.** Contains sodden paper, quills, ink wells, magnifying glasses, 57 GP.

► **Papers.** Washed out. Decrees from Duke Avito: “All must worship Vermesh. All chapels and shrines are to be demolished immediately. The red priests are to be obeyed in all matters.”

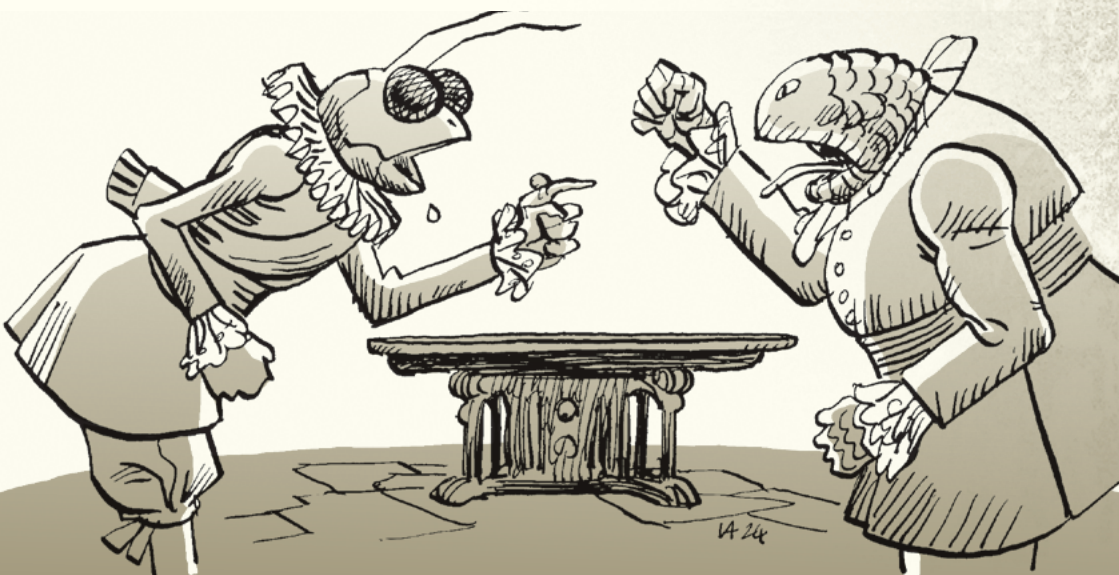
► **Boxes.** Contain tiny wooden ships and soldiers (for military planning). **Curse:** anyone who handles the figures must save vs spells or be compelled for d6 hours to respond to any spoken suggestion with: “Yes, I think that’s a really good idea.”

29. East stairs

Danger. 2-in-6 chances of a refreshed lovey horror (p. 37) coming down to hunt and play.

Wide stone stairs spiral up from level 1 to level 2. They also spiral down toward the cellar, but stop abruptly at a solid **iron door**.

► **Iron door.** Locked (to keep prisoners downstairs). When the door is opened, a flood of cold filthy water pours down the stairs and into the **blazing barracks** (p. 39), where it cools the lava into solid rock and the air fills with scalding steam. In d6 hours, the lava begins flowing up through the cracks again.





◆ LEVEL 2

30. Sharksuite

Danger. Damage is all from thunder and lightning, two weeks old. Each turn, 1-in-6 chance of ceiling or wall collapsing (d6 damage).

Cold rain blows in through the shattered windows. A four-poster bed stands on coral tiles, surrounded by charred ebony furnishings, shark-patterned wallpaper, tattered sharkskin curtains, and an oversized private bath. The floor is littered with broken **toy soldiers** and dead **servants**. A **corpse** hangs from a silk noose above the bed.

➤ **Toy soldiers.** Solid silver, together worth 300 GP.

➤ **Servants.** Two maids, two footmen. Bruised necks (strangled). When touched, all four rise as **chaos zombies** (p. 36).

➤ **Corpse.** Violet velvet suit, white silk cravat, bulbous fish eyes. Curled blue wig on the floor. Silver shark brooch (100 GP). Full of corpse flies. White porcelain **mask** on the floor.

MASK OF SELACHI - Enchanted. Wearer's bones turn to soft cartilage, can easily squeeze through narrow gaps. -4 to melee attacks and other Str based rolls.

31. Spider suite

Danger. Damage is all from thunder and lightning, two weeks old. Each turn, 1-in-6 chance of ceiling or wall collapsing (d6 damage).

Cold rain blows in through the shattered windows. A four-poster bed stands on a sticky white carpet, surrounded by charred ebony furnishings; spider-patterned wallpaper; white spider-silk curtains; and a smashed private bath.

A **woman** sits on the bed, reading a blood-spattered **book**.

➤ **Woman.** *Miss Imogen* (25), **lovely horror** (p. 36). Plain black dress, white porcelain mask, silver spider brooch (100 GP). Shy, bookish.

➤ **Wants:** To be left alone to read.

➤ **Hates:** Interruptions.

➤ **If spoken to:** She shushes you.

➤ **If spoken to again:** She leaps across the room onto you and tears off her porcelain mask to reveal a furry, many-eyed, spider face, and vomits webbing onto your mouth. Save vs breath or be unable to speak for 2d6 hours. Burn the webbing to remove it immediately (d4 damage).

➤ **Book.** Old-fashioned romantic sonnets.

32. Crab suite

Danger. Damage is all from thunder and lightning, two weeks old. Each turn, 1-in-6 chance of ceiling or wall collapsing (d6 damage).

Cold rain blows in through the shattered windows. A four-poster **bed** stands on tiles of crushed red shells, surrounded by charred ebony furnishings, crab-patterned wallpaper, tattered red silk curtains, and an overflowing private bath. A **man** lies in the bathtub. Bright red blood has sprayed across the white fixtures and tiles.

➤ **Man.** Elderly, naked, red crab-chitin skin (**lovely horror**, p. 37). Throat torn out by large bird-like talons (**motley magpie**, p. 37). An **ebony cane** cradled in his cold arms.

EBONY CANE - This black walking stick has a red jade handle carved into an octopus. When the bearer sleeps in water, they have euphoric dreams and recover 1 hp per hour, but cannot wake on their own.

➤ **Bed.** 3-in-6 chance the **motley magpie** (p. 37) is hiding in a heap of blankets on the bed (nesting).

33. Beetle suite

Danger. Damage is all from thunder and lightning, two weeks old. Each turn, 1-in-6 chance of ceiling or wall collapsing (d6 damage).

Cold rain blows in through the shattered windows. A four-poster bed stands on iridescent black tiles, surrounded by charred ebony furnishings, beetle-patterned wallpaper, tattered green silk curtains, a burnt **side table**, and a smashed private bath. A pale **man** in a red robe lies on the floor, a **dagger** in his heart.

➤ **Man.** Dead (stabbed). He has no eyes and no left arm (magically consumed by Vermesh). Wears amulet of Vermesh (300 GP). Covered in tiny red worms (eating the flesh).

➤ **Worms.** Inching, nibbling. Whispering “Ver...mesh... Ver...mesh...” When harmed, the worms swarm together to form a **ravenous wyrmling** (p. 37)

➤ **Dagger.** Viola’s stiletto. Slender mirror blade, golden hilt, sapphire pommel (300 GP).

➤ **Side table.** On it sits a white ivory box, its sides carved into detailed, lifelike beetles. Anyone who looks at the box must save vs spells or be cursed for d6 hours to desire whatever is inside the box. Currently in the box are hundreds of old stained toe-nail clippings. If multiple people are cursed, then they fight for the contents of the box. Each time a cursed person is harmed, they may repeat the save to end the curse.

34. Tiger suite

Danger. Damage is all from thunder and lightning, two weeks old. Each turn, 1-in-6 chance of ceiling or wall collapsing (d6 damage).

Cold rain blows in through the shattered windows. A four-post bed stands on a blackened tiger-skin carpet, surrounded by charred ebony furnishings; tiger-patterned wallpaper; shredded, orange-and-white silk curtains; a large **fireplace**; and a dusty private bath. Two **women** sit motionless on the floor, embracing, each driving a knife into the other's back. Tiny **eyes** stare out from under the furniture all around.

► **Women.** Not dead (both clumsy with knives.) Twin sisters: *Lady Julia* and *Lady Juliet* (55), **lovely horrors** (p. 37). Shredded black lace dresses, ruined blue wigs. Mutant tiger faces and claws. Silver tiger brooches (100 GP). One wears a single **black pearl** earring.

► **Wants:** To die by noble hands (not servants or the motley magpie).

► **Fears:** The touch of peasants.

► **Eyes.** Nine black cats hiding from the cold rain. One wears a collar with a **black pearl** charm.

BLACK PEARLS (EARRINGS) - The creatures wearing these paired pearls can exchange telepathic messages, up to 500 feet (3/day).

Note: *Cat thoughts are simple emotions: cold. Hungry. Annoyed. Bored. Sleepy (exactly what you would expect).*

► **Fireplace.** Large, cold, wet. Can be climbed to access **banquet hall** below (p. 46) and **Duke Avito's room** above (p. 63).

35. Unicorn suite

Danger. Damage is all from thunder and lightning, two weeks old. Each turn, 1-in-6 chance of ceiling or wall collapsing (d6 damage).

Cold rain blows in through the shattered windows. A four-poster bed stands on a silvery white carpet, surrounded by charred ivory furnishings; unicorn-patterned wallpaper; torn, white silk curtains; an ivory **side table**; and a gleaming private bath. A **short couple** waltz on the bed, humming a strange discordant melody. Eight **naked bodies** lie scattered about the floor.

► **Couple.** *Count and Countess Malvolio* (40), lovely horrors (p. 37). White silk bathrobes, silver unicorn brooches (100 GP). Mutant unicorn horns and hooves. They scream at you to leave them alone!

► **Wants:** To dance, deeply in love. A bit hungry.

► **Naked bodies.** Identical copies of the Count and Countess (created by magic eggs). Gored open (by horns). Hearts and livers missing (eaten). Eight broken, blue egg shells on the floor.

► **Side table** Gleaming ebony box on the side table with twelve dimples: eight empty, four contain **blue eggs**.

BLUE EGGS - Break an egg on a creature to create a lifeless clone of that creature.

36. Falcon suite

Danger. Damage is all from thunder and lightning, two weeks old. Each turn, 1-in-6 chance of ceiling or wall collapsing (d6 damage).

Cold rain blows in through the shattered **windows**. A four-poster bed stands on a blackened blue carpet, surrounded by charred ebony furnishings; falcon-patterned wallpaper; tattered, brown feathery curtains; and a tiny private bath. A **pale woman** in a red robe lies face-up in the overflowing tub. A **slender figure** in a beaked mask inspects the body.



➤ **Windows.** A climber could access the **Dragon suite** (opposite) and **private theater** (p. 59).

➤ **Woman.** Dead (drowned). She has no eyes and no left arm (magically consumed by Vermesh). Wears amulet of Vermesh (300 GP). Covered in tiny **red worms** (eating the flesh).

➤ **Worms.** Inching, nibbling. Whispering “Ver...mesh... Ver...mesh...” When harmed, the worms swarm together to form a **ravenous wyrmling** (p. 37).

➤ **Figure.** *Professor Marinda Boaj* (35), plague doctor from a distant land. Leather coat, gloves, **mask**, hat. Pale, short red hair. Curious, fearless, awkward. Willing to join the party.

▶ **Wants:** To learn about mutants.

▶ **Fears:** Illness, refuses to remove her mask. Studying the red priest corpse.

▶ **Knows:** That the red priests sacrificed their eyes and arms to Vermesh to gain spirit-sight and ghost-limbs. Suspects that Vermesh is in the keep, radiating chaos. Also knows that the **holy staff of Vitela** can banish a true horror; the staff is rumored to be hidden on Isla Requía.

▶ **If Marinda's mask is removed:** She instantly mutates into a **plague raven**.

▶ **If Marinda sees a corpse:** She will examine it. There is a 1-in-6 chance that Marinda's clumsy examination accidentally turns a body into a **chaos zombie** (p. 36).

PROFESSOR MARINDA BOAJ - *A curious and knowledgeable plague doctor.*

AC 7 [12] (plague leathers), **HD** 2 (9 hp),

Att 1 x knife (1d6), **THAC0** 18 [+1], **MV** 60' (20'),

SV D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 9, **AL** Lawful,

XP 35

▶ **Masked:** Immune to disease and mutation, and other inhaled effects.

PLAGUE RAVEN - A skilled foreign doctor who succumbed to maddening bird-like mutations.

AC 5 [14], **HD** 3 (13 hp), Att 2 × claw (1d6, poison) or parasite swarm, **THACO** 17 [+2], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D12 W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 9, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 100

► **Poison:** Causes death in 1d6 turns (save versus poison).

► **Parasite Swarm:** The raven shakes off a 20' cloud of tiny black parasites that attach to clothing and flesh (2/day). Save vs poison, or roll 1d6 for a plague lasting d6 turns:

1. **Red Rage** (berserk, attack random targets).

2. **Blue Death** (freezing, unable to move or act) 3. **Wax Rot** (flesh drips off the bone, d6 ongoing) 4. **Needle Pox** (grow long painful needles, 1 damage when moving) 5. **Spider Flu** (venomous spiders continuously crawl out of orifices) 6. **Mutation** (become a plague raven).

POXMASTER MASK - Wearer is immune to disease and mutation, and other inhaled effects.

37. Dragon suite

Danger. Damage is all from thunder and lightning, two weeks old. Each turn, 1-in-6 chance of ceiling or wall collapsing (d6 damage).

Cold rain blows in through the shattered windows. A four-poster bed stands on shimmering obsidian tiles, surrounded by charred ebony furnishings; dragon-patterned wallpaper; metallic leather curtains; and a smashed private bath. The outer wall is gone. Every surface crawls with tiny red worms. A pale woman in a red robe stands gazing out the broken wall, three mangled bodies at her feet.

► **Worms.** Inching, nibbling. Whispering "Ver...mesh... Ver...mesh..." When harmed, the worms swarm together to form a ravenous wyrm (p. 36).

► **Woman.** Sycorax (40), red priest. She

has no eyes and no left arm (magically consumed by Vermesh). Wears amulet of Vermesh (300 GP).

► **Wants:** To find Vermesh, knows It is in the keep.

► **Fears:** Princess Viola.

► **Bodies.** Servants, electrocuted by Sycorax. When Sycorax fights, she animates them as three chaos zombies (p. 36) under her control.

► **Wall.** Possible to climb outside horizontally to the private theater (p. 55).

► **Item.** Blue jade chess set (500 GP).

38. Linen closet

Danger. 1-in-6 chance of a lovely horror (p. 37) gnawing on a dead servant.

This small chamber is lined with simple wooden shelves and bins.

► **Small chamber.** Large enough to fit several people, crowded together.

► **Shelves and bins.** Sheets, pillows, towels, napkins, tablecloths, drop cloths, curtains, rags.

39. Liquor closet

Danger. 1-in-6 chance of a lovely horror (p. 37) gnawing on a dead servant.

This small chamber is lined with simple wooden shelves and bins.

► **Small chamber.** Large enough to fit several people, crowded together.

► **Shelves and bins.** Wine, absinthe, rum, gin, brandy, whiskey, vodka, glasses, trays.

40. Secret passages

These narrow access corridors only allow movement in single file. The paneled walls and tiled floors are pristine. Thick candles sit in iron sconces. A large dark mass lies on the floor.

► **Floors.** Used to be cleaned and maintained. No signs of damage.

► **Thick candles.** Burnt out, melted.

► **Mass.** Two lovely horrors (dead),

mutant feathers and beaks, transmuted into black marble, mid-coitus. Creaking **floorboards** when approached.

➤ **Floorboards.** The marble bodies are now incredibly heavy. When stepped on, they crash through the floor into the **banquet hall** (p. 46) below.

41. Silver chapel

Obsidian **buttresses** edged in silver leaves and blossoms arch up to a painted domed **ceiling**. Black marble pews sit before a silver **altar**, flanked by four small **alcoves** in the walls.

➤ **Buttresses.** Gothic, ribbed, tiny hidden details (screaming faces, clawing hands, skulls).

➤ **Ceiling.** Painted with a mural of sea creatures (octopus, shark, jellyfish) spiraling around the sea angel Rahavil (silver feathers orbiting three flaming eyes).

➤ **Pews.** Six. Each has a rare prayer book of Rahavil: five torn and burned (intentionally defaced), one intact (1,000 GP).

➤ **Altar.** Ebony, silver plated, sea creatures (heavy, 3,000 GP). A twisted block of red jade (**Chaos idol of Vermesh**, 5,000 GP) on display. On the floor: silver candlesticks (300 GP), smashed bottle of white wine, smashed vase of (holy) sea water, burnt hymns, crushed silver bells, scattered incense, mangled silver figurine of the sea angel Rahavil (little silver feathers around three silver eyes, 1,000 GP).

➤ **Silver.** Solid silver details, can be broken off, 25 GP each (52 in total).

➤ **Alcoves.** Four. Each displays an antique inkaran porcelain vase (dark blue with silver patterns), 300 GP each. One contains a small silver sphere (**Eye of Rahavil**).

➤ **Seal.** Graven in the stone, representing Rahavil. When the silver figurine of Rahavil is moved past the seal, the door slams shut and the chapel quickly fills with sea water (vibrates right before).

CHAOS IDOL OF VERMESH -

Abstract, hideous.

➤ **Effect:** Lawful creatures cannot cast spells or heal in the chapel.

➤ **Cursed:** Idol bearer must save vs death each day or mutate into a **ravenous wyrm** (p. 37). Effect can only be ended by a 24-hour vigil with a Lawful priest.

EYE OF RAHAVIL - *Not really an angel eye.*

Bearer is immune to drowning. They still lose consciousness for 2d6 turns.

42. Quiet nook

Impossibly soft white fur **carpets** silence all footsteps in this windowless **room**. Sky-blue velvet **couches** and small silver **tables** encircle an elegant obsidian **fountain**, babbling with eight arching streams of clear water.

➤ **Room.** Thin cracks in walls and floor (thunder-damaged).

➤ **Carpets.** Albino sea snake fur (rare). 500 GP per bolt (six bolts).

➤ **Couches.** Very comfy. Room on each for two, maybe three...

➤ **Tables.** Long silk ribbons, assorted scented oils.

➤ **Fountain.** Enchanted. Realistic obsidian statues of eight entwined boas and vipers spitting water. Magically recycles the **water**.

➤ **Water.** Enchanted. When drunk, save vs petrification or roll d6 for random physical transformation:

1. Slender man 2. Muscular man
3. Voluptuous man 4. Slender woman
5. Muscular woman 6. Voluptuous woman.

43. Glass garden

The glass ceiling of this small **greenhouse** lies in glittering **granules** on the **muddy floor**. Dozens of **charred flowers** lie bent and crushed in shattered ceramic pots.

► **Greenhouse.** Completely exposed, cold rain blowing in.

► **Granules.** Sharp, shiny, crunchy.

► **Muddy floor.** Rain plus spilled dirt.

► **Item:** Tiny golden box buried in the mud. Enchanted. When the box is opened, the blue pearl fixed inside plays soothing violin concertos. Stops when closed (300 GP).

► **Charred flowers.** Lightning-struck.

Dead, but d6 bulbs remain (200 GP each). Roll d6 for each:

- **1-2.** Black orchid (pain-free intoxication for d6 hours)

- **3-4.** Starlight jasmine (intensely heightened senses for d6 hours)

- **5-6.** Moonrise lotus (incapable of sleep but fatigue free for 24 hours).

44. Billiards room

Cold rain blows in through the shattered windows, spraying the charred walls and floor. A scorched billiards table lies broken and askew. The floor creaks loudly. Three figures stand in a huddle, whispering excitedly.

► **Shattered windows.** Thunder.

► **Charred walls.** Blackened by lightning. twelve obsidian alcoves displaying twelve cut sapphires. Each cut gem is actually a hibernating flesh-eating sapphire scarab (p. 50). If removed from the room, they awaken in 1 turn and attack the thieves as a swarm.

► **Table.** Six pockets containing nine billiards balls of solid sapphire (250GP each).

► **Floor.** Weak. 2-in-6 chance of collapse, falling into the banquet hall (p. 47).

► **Figures.** *Vlad, Boris, and Arkady* (40), scavengers (p. 23) from another island. Dripping leather coats, muddy boots, cloth masks. Practical, amoral.

► **Wants:** Maximum treasure.

► **Fears:** Illness and mutation. Not looking for trouble. Not looking to make friends. Currently examining a solid sapphire billiard ball.

► **Has:** Loot sack containing assorted coins and jewelry worth 3,500 GP.

45. Private theater

Cold rain blows through the charred gaps in the walls where the windows used to be. Burnt remains of velvet couches and fur rugs litter the room. The frame of a small puppet theater stands blackened and damp.

► **Gaps.** Thunder and lightning damage. Easily climbed on the outside up to Prince Orsino's room (p. 60) or horizontally to the falcon and dragon suites (pp. 55-57)

► **Remains.** Useless, worthless.

► **Theater.** Mostly destroyed. Under tattered velvet, a heavy leather case.

► **Case.** Undamaged, unlocked. Contains eight stunningly lifelike puppets of men and women in violet velvet suits and dresses, blue wigs. Anatomically correct. 50 GP each.

46. Mews

Melted iron bars cover the small circular windows around this small circular room. A charred mess lies near the door. Eight wooden perches ring the room. Seven are damaged, and seven birds lie still on the floor. A small falcon sits on the eighth perch, gazing out the barred window.

► **Mess.** Burned wicker baskets. Scorched rabbit scraps. Lightly charred falconer gloves, lures, jesses, leashes, hoods.

► **Perches.** Burnt, splintered.

► **Birds.** Assorted hawks, kestrels, gyrfalcons. Dead. Holes burned straight through them.

► **Falcon.** *Lady Isabeau*, mutant hunting bird (tethered to the perch). Lazy, never flies. Glowing red eyes, shoots scorching rays (d6 damage) at creatures (only small prey animals and annoying people). Loyal to a calm, quiet person who feeds her. Dangerous and unpredictable to everyone else.

LADY ISABEAU - *A mutant falcon.*

AC 8 [11], **HD** 1 (4 hp), **Att** 1 x heat vision (1d4),
THACO 19 [+0], **MV** 480' (160') flying, **SV** D12
W13 P14 B15 S16, **ML** 7, **AL** Neutral, **XP** 10

► **Lazy:** Prefers not to fly. Sits on master's gloved fist and shoots heat beams from her glowing red eyes.

► **Petty:** Prefers to target small prey animals and people who annoy her.

47. East stairs

Wide stone stairs spiral down to level 1.

► **Danger.** 2-in-6 chance of a weary lovely horror (p. 37) coming up to bed.

48. South stairs

Wide stone stairs spiral up to level 3.

Danger. 2-in-6 chance of a wary red priest (p. 37) coming down to find something to sacrifice to Vermesh.

◆ LEVEL 3

49. South stairs

Danger. 2-in-6 chance of a scared red priest (p. 37) flirring up to escape Princess Viola.

Wide stone stairs spiral down to level 2.

50. Prince Orsino's room

An obsidian door sits in a black iron frame, which has twisted into the shapes of dozens of iron hands clasp the door closed. The handle is white iron, which has twisted into the shape of a screaming face.

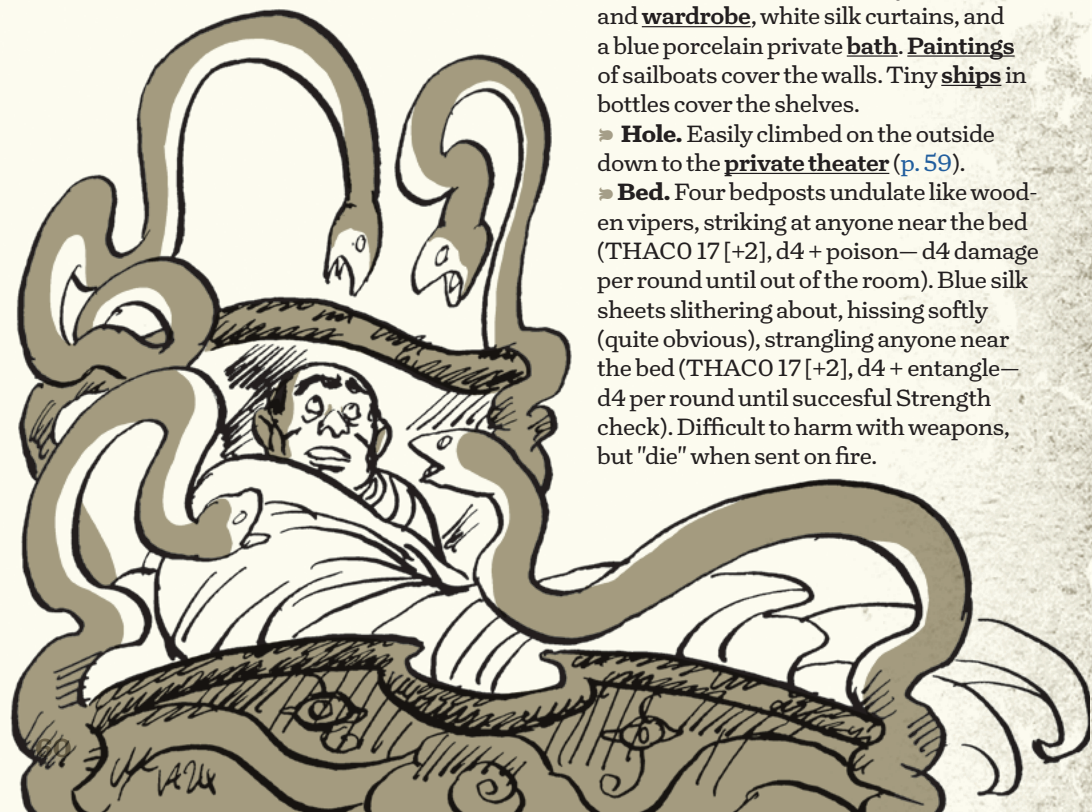
► **Door.** Magically reinforced. Would take 12 turns/person using tools to break down.

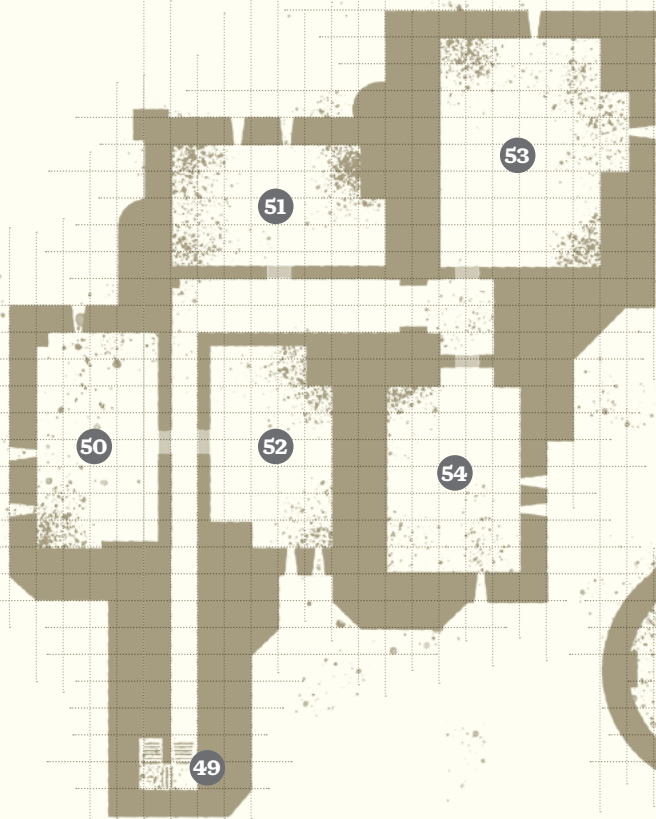
► **Handle.** Looks like Prince Orsino screaming. No longer a working handle.

• **Inside.** Cold rain blows in through a large gaping hole in the outer wall. A four-poster bed stands on a smooth obsidian floor, surrounded by teak desk and wardrobe, white silk curtains, and a blue porcelain private bath. Paintings of sailboats cover the walls. Tiny ships in bottles cover the shelves.

► **Hole.** Easily climbed on the outside down to the private theater (p. 59).

► **Bed.** Four bedposts undulate like wooden vipers, striking at anyone near the bed (THACO 17 [+2], d4 + poison—d4 damage per round until out of the room). Blue silk sheets slithering about, hissing softly (quite obvious), strangling anyone near the bed (THACO 17 [+2], d4 + entangle—d4 per round until successful Strength check). Difficult to harm with weapons, but "die" when sent on fire.





All third floor windows are tall, narrow, lead-paned (distorted and yellowed). Iron bars (painted violet) protect the frames, so that nothing larger than a cat can slip in or out.

► **Desk.** Daily diary: Prince Orsino was bored with palace life, wanted to become a sailor, have adventures, fight pirates (be a pirate?), Working up the courage to tell his parents. Iron box containing 324 GP. Gleaming **obsidian box**.

► **Obsidian box.** Filled with gold silk, circular indent. Place **Orsino's circlet** in the box to summon a sylph (p. 69).

► **Wardrobe.** Sailor pea coat, tricorn hat. Ancient nautical charts (500 GP), sextant, compass, spyglass.

► **Bath.** Cursed. The tub groans and squeals, then breaks free of the floor, gallops about, kicking and smashing everything at random.

► **Paintings.** Cursed, fire tiny broadsides at anyone who stands in front of them (d4 damage). Advanced experimental ship

designs, detailed diagrams hidden on the back sides (1,000 GP).

► **Ships.** Twelve well-made children's toys. The "water" under each model is a lump of pure silver (100 GP each).

51. Princess Viola's room

(An obsidian **door** sits in a black iron frame. The **handle** is white iron.

► **Door.** Magically reinforced. Would take 12 turns/person using tools to break down.

► **Handle.** Locked. Requires a white iron key (**Banquet hall**, p. 46).

► **Inside.** Cold wind whistles through the mangled barred windows. A four-post **bed** stands on a smooth obsidian floor, surrounded by gilt ebony **desk** and **wardrobe**, gold silk curtains, and a blue porcelain private **bath**. Hundreds of small **papers** are pinned to the walls.

➤ **Bed.** Tangled sweaty sheets. Tiny red worms crawl and nibble the sheets. Examination reveals that the legs of the ebony bed are partly clear glass.

➤ **Desk.** Crumpled papers, lists of rooms and names crossed out. Iron box containing 619 GP. Gleaming **obsidian box** filled with gold silk with a circular indent.

➤ **Obsidian box.** Contains gold silk with a circular indent. Place **Viola's circlet** in the box to summon a sylph (p. 69).

➤ **Wardrobe.** Dresses strewn on the floor. Random weapons piled high: 19 swords, 34 daggers, 11 maces, 7 hand axes, 4 flails.

➤ **Papers.** Lawful prayer scrolls of protection, to prevent mutation (incorrectly punctuated, ineffective). Behind the papers, patches of the wooden walls are clear glass with tiny red worms wriggling inside like an ant-farm.

➤ **Bath.** Long black hairs and tiny **red worms** everywhere. Examination reveals that the bottom of the bath is partly clear glass.

➤ **Worms.** Inching, nibbling. Whispering "Ver...mesh... Ver...mesh..." When harmed, the worms swarm together to form a **ravenous wyrm**ling (p. 37).

52. Princess Bianca's room

An obsidian **door** stands ajar in a black iron frame. The **handle** is white iron, which has twisted into a striking scorpion tail.

➤ **Door.** Open. When crossing the threshold, the obsidian door fires dozens of obsidian needles at the intruder (THACO 17 [+2], 2d6 damage). Wearing any royal **circlet** (pp. 24, 47, 63) disarms the trap.

➤ **Handle.** Scorpion tail stings any who touch it (d6).

➤ **Inside.** Cold wind whistles through the mangled barred windows. A four-poster **bed** stands on a smooth obsidian floor, surrounded by an ivory **desk** and **wardrobe**, pink silk curtains, and a blue

porcelain private **bath**. Hundreds of **porcelain dolls** sit on the shelves.

➤ **Bed.** Four white bedposts twisted into giant human fingers, skitters like a huge clumsy spider, slamming into walls. A large ragdoll (enchanted toy, harmless, dimwit, wants to help Bianca) sits on the pink silk sheets, shouting at the bed: "Left! No my left! The other left! Back up! Try again!"

➤ **Desk.** Tons of cheap costume jewelry. Iron box containing 3 GP. Gleaming **obsidian box**.

➤ **Obsidian box.** Filled with gold silk, circular indent. Place **Bianca's circlet** in the box to summon a sylph (p. 69).

➤ **Wardrobe.** Big poofy dresses, all colors. More porcelain dolls.

➤ **Bath.** More porcelain dolls.

➤ **Porcelain dolls.** Their eyes follow the party. Giggle eerily. At the scariest possible moment, they leap off the shelves to pile on top of the party, giggling madly. Easily escaped, but after 3 rounds, they all burst open to spill thousands of red worms, which swarm together to form six **ravenous wyrm**lings (p. 37).

53. Duchess Forza's room

Obsidian and gold **furniture** shines in the dim light. Ancient **books** and amber **spheres** line the shelves. There are five sphere-sized **alcoves** in the walls around the room. A highbacked **chair** sits on the rain-soaked balcony, facing the harbor.

➤ **Furniture.** Gorgeous, yet uncomfortable to sit on or lay on. Most objects are carved from human hand bones or bird skulls. Tiny, glass bird figurines line the shelves (100 GP).

➤ **Books.** All in dead languages. Disturbing illustrations of sea monsters and spellcraft. References to speaking to or capturing ghosts and souls. (1,200 GP). Searching reveals scrolls of *lightning bolt*, *phantasmal force*, *magic missile* and *levitate*.

► **Spheres.** 23. Each charged with raging storm energy. Smash one, deal d6 damage to a 20-foot radius.

► **Alcoves.** Insert an amber sphere to activate.

► **Bedside.** A dim red light glows, soft music plays.

► **Desk.** Amber lamps ignite, a fan spins lazily.

► **Mirror.** Presents a view of the harbor through the eyes of the colossus (p. 16).

► **Balcony.** A black silk canopy extends to shade the chair. The air warms and smells of lavender.

► **Oil portrait.** The painting (portait of the ducal family) vanishes to reveal a walk-in closet, the true vault. Dozens of small locked iron chests. Contain a total of 9,000 GP in loose sapphires and 4,000 GP in assorted gold currencies.

► **Chair.** The Duchess Forza, 55, sorcerer queen. A charred corpse in a black dress, her chest exploded, an ashen cavity where her heart should be. Tiny red worms writhe in her sockets. A **gold crown** on her head. A **white staff** in her hand. She cannot move, but can speak.

► **Asks:** “*Did I destroy the fleet? Did I save the palace?*”

“*Where are my children? Where are Orsino, and Viola, and Bianca?*”

► **If convinced that she saved the palace and her children are fine:** She gratefully crumbles to dust.

► **If told that the area is destroyed or her children are gone:** She screams. A bolt of red lightning destroys her body, deals 2d6 damage to everyone near her (save vs breath to take half damage), and sends her staff flying into the sea.

► **Staff.** Different bones bound together with iron rings, topped with a human skull.

FORZA'S STAFF - Made of the bones of dead magicians, including the skull of the mad wizard Prospero, who offers unhelpful comments. The bearer is immune to lightning, can summon storm clouds, and can cast azure lightning (d6 to five targets or 5d6 to one target, 1/day).

FORZA'S CROWN - Solid gold set with black pearls and sapphires. Doubles the range, duration, or power of any spell (1/day).

54. Duke Avito's room

An obsidian **door** sits in a black iron frame shaped like a single wrinkled worm. The **handle** is white iron, shaped like a serrated fang.

► **Door.** Magically reinforced. Would take 12 turns/person using tools to break down. Locked.

► **Magic trap:** when crossing the threshold, a dozen ghost-worms (snake-sized) materialize to scream loudly and to bite the intruder (1d12 damage). Victim is electrically shocked and must save vs paralysis or is unable to move for 1d6 turns.

► **Handle.** Fang is very sharp.

► **Inside.** Crumpled iron plates cover the windows. There is no furniture. Large **fireplace**. Thousands of **cracks** line the ceiling and walls. Wrinkled red blankets lie in the corners, and a blue porcelain private **bath** to one side. Lit red candles cover the obsidian floor, illuminating hundreds of blood-red **runes** on the tiles, and three chanting **red priests**. A **silver circlet** with blue pearls (1,000 GP) lies on the ground, aside

BIANCA'S CIRCLLET.

► **When placed in its case in Bianca's room** (p. 62), it summons a sylph (Tiny pink six-winged moth-man, bard caste, intelligent but does not speak), which entertains whoever last touched Bianca's circlet (soothing music and lights.) for 1d6 hours 1/day.

► **If worn:**

- Gain +1 CHA.

- Disables the trap at the door of Bianca's room.

➤ **Cracks.** Thunder damage. Any damage to the ceiling or walls causes the room to collapse (4d6, save vs breath for half damage).

➤ **Runes.** Ancient, Chaos: “*Hunger. Spirit. Death. Life. Worm.*” Summoning the horror Vermesh.

➤ **Priests.** *Godric, Harlow, Ravenna* (60), chaos cultists (red priests). They have no eyes and no left arms (magically consumed by vermesh).

▶ **Has:** 3 x amulet of Vermesh (300 GP).

▶ **Wants:** The summoning of Vermesh to be completed.

▶ **Knows:** It is happening in the private sanctum.

▶ **Defends:** The bath.

▶ **Fears:** Princess Viola.

➤ **Bath.** Empty, filthy. Caked in dried mud and foul stains (faint bootprints). Enchanted (Chaos). A secret portal.

➤ **Secret portal.** When a person stands in the muddy tub, they are teleported to the private sanctum (see below), where they arrive in a room without windows or doors, standing in a pile of chaos mud (which can teleport them back).

➤ **Fireplace.** Large, cold, wet. Can be climbed down to access the tiger suite (p. 55), and further below to the banquet hall (p. 47).

55. Private sanctum

A pale shaft of light falls through a jagged gash in the roof of this domed chamber.

A body lies against the wall near dozens of dead animals. A woman trembles, spread-eagled and chained on the floor. A white crystal knife stands in her still-beating heart.

➤ **Domed chamber.** The private sanctum is an isolated unfinished space above level 3 inside a decorative dome atop the obsidian keep. It has no doors or windows. Adventurers could climb in and out

Note: Duke Avito spent the last year sacrificing animals, trying to summon Vermesh to gain magic powers. During the battle, he tried to sacrifice his youngest child Bianca, which half-summoned Vermesh and caused the red storm. The Duke fumbled the knife, Vermesh bit off his arm (fatal), and Bianca was left in limbo.

through the damaged dome (dangerous) or smash through the floor to descend into Duke Avito's room (p. 63).

➤ **Body.** Male, 55, dead, right arm torn off (missing). The Duke Avito. Black robes, golden chains set with rubies (600 GP), a bloody crown on the floor, a ring of 13 keys in his pocket (unlock Bianca's chains and every door in the keep).

➤ **Avito's crown.** Solid gold set with blue pearls and sapphires. 3,000 GP.

➤ **Animals.** Chickens, goats, up to a year dead. All stabbed in the heart, identical wounds (from the crystal knife).

➤ **Woman. Princess Bianca** (20), still alive! Blood-soaked black dress, pale, gaunt, but fierce. Trembling, she whispers: “*Don't touch the knife...*”

▶ **If the crystal knife is touched:** An unseen creature bites off an arm (lose 2d6 hp) and takes it away to its native plane.

▶ **If Bianca is touched:** Become able to see a huge ethereal worm rising from her body like a giant cobra.

➤ **Worm.** Vermesh, an immortal cosmic horror. Trapped in an incomplete ritual. Speaks in a small giggling rasp.

▶ **Wants:** To complete the ritual and enter this reality so It can taste its delights.

▶ **Offers:** Vermesh will give the Void-flesh Blessing to who completes the ritual. (It does not explain what this means.) It says one must drive the crystal knife entirely into Bianca's body. Vermesh does not trust mortals, so the character must place one arm in Its maw as collateral.

▶ **If the knife is pushed in:** Bianca dies and Vermesh materializes in the chamber. The character is released



and receives the Voidflesh Blessing. Vermesh then begins eating the dead animals, growing very quickly.

► **If the knife is pulled out:** Vermesh bites off your arm and vanishes into the ether. Bianca can then be healed. The keys to her chains are in the Duke's pocket.

► **Voidflesh blessing.** The character's skin closes over their eyes, blinding them. They gain the ability to sense shapes and movement up to 60 feet using their hearing. They can consume any living or non-living material as food. They are immune to disease

CRYSTAL KNIFE - This ancient magic blade is a tooth stolen from one of the five seraphim, the engines of creation. It can pierce anything in the universe, but only does 1d4 damage.

VERMESH - A true eldritch horror that was once banished from reality, and now wishes to return. Its true form is a gigantic red worm with randomly arranged (and shifting) golden eyes, and a circular mouth with golden shark-like teeth. It has grown weak during its time in limbo, and now wishes to feed to regain its former strength. Cares nothing for humanity, and barely acknowledges its worshippers as minor appendages of its own will and body.

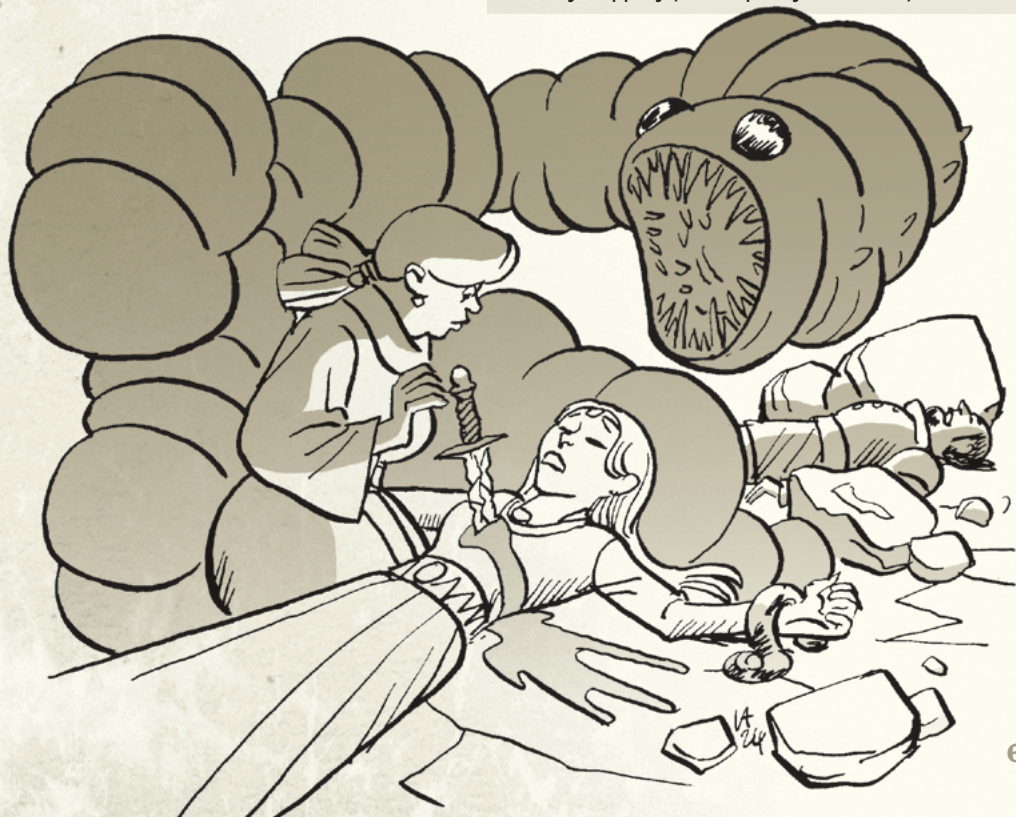
AC -2 [21], **HD** 16 (72 hp), **Att** 1 x bite (3d8, sever), **THAC0** 8 [+11], **MV** 120' (40'), **SV** D2 W3 P4 B3 S6, **ML** 12, **AL** Chaotic, **XP** 2,300

► **Sever:** The target loses a limb (save vs death). Roll 1d4: 1, Right arm. 2, Left arm. 3, Right leg. 4, Left leg.

► **Nightmare Aura:** All creatures within 20' of the horror must save vs spells or be blinded by nightmarish visions of continuously unfolding and exploding human bodies.

► **Immunity.** Slimy flesh is immune to fire and lightning.

► **Slippery.** The horror oozes slime. The ground next to it is always slippery (save vs paralysis to move).



ENDING THE ADVENTURE

If Vermesh is not defeated...

...then Chaos continues to infect the island. The lovely horrors and the stranded humans continue to develop monstrous physical mutations and to descend into feral savagery. They feed upon each other until only a small number of truly demonic creatures remain, trapped on the island. Civilized peoples declare the island a hazard to all humanity and forbid anyone to go there.

Of course, someone eventually will...

If Vermesh is defeated...

...then the forces of Chaos fade away. Most of the invasive monsters retreat into the earth or sea. The lovely horrors become weaker as they starve. The stranded serfs and servants beg for safe passage to the mainland, or assemble their own rafts and boats to attempt the journey (most will reach the nearby coast alive). The ruined Obsidian Keep itself stands empty for a few years, until another exiled cult or band of pirates moves in to use the keep as their new base of operations (a problem for future adventurers, no doubt).

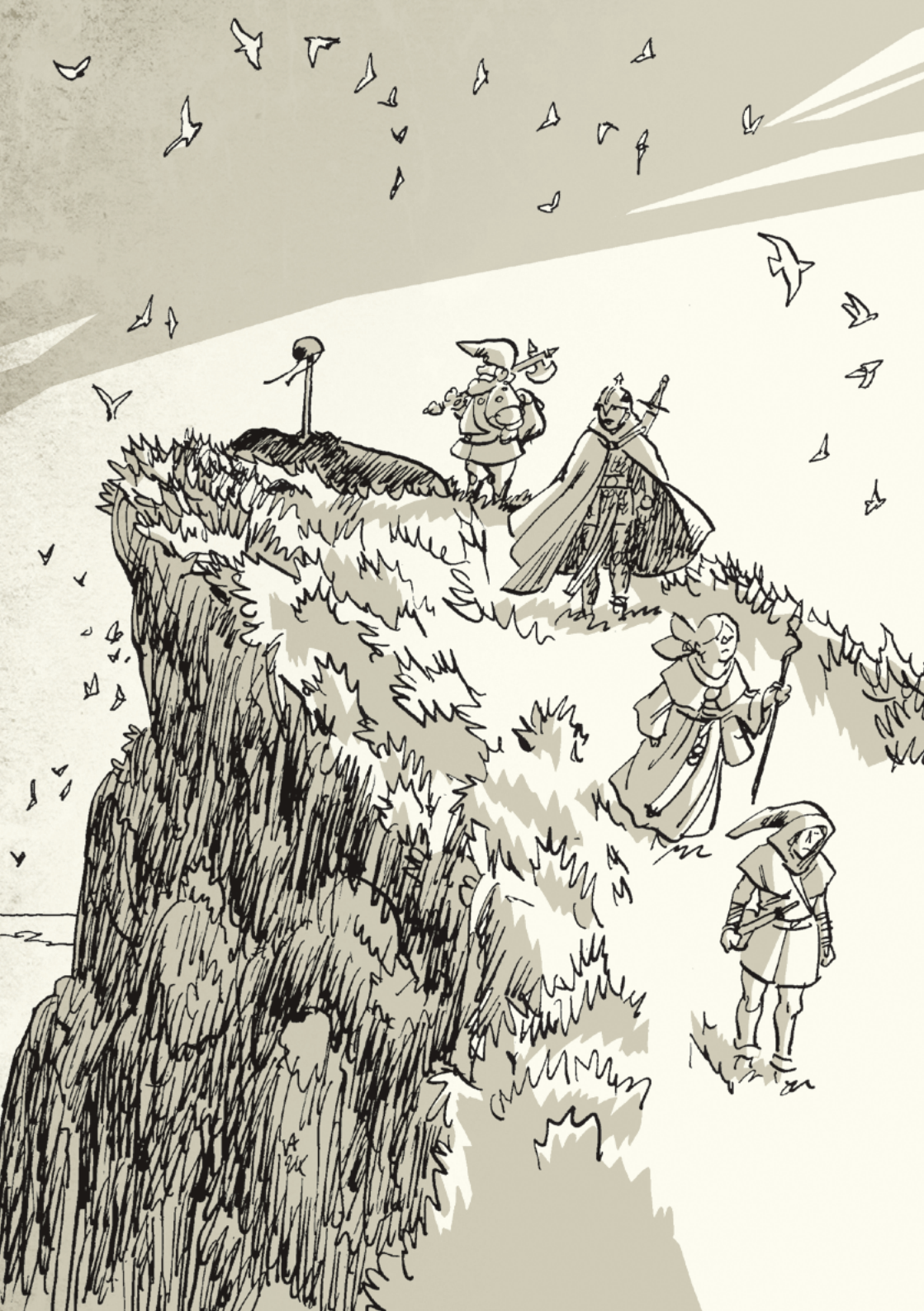
If either of the princesses Viola or Bianca survives...

...then they travel to the mainland and take up a lifelong pilgrimage to bolster the forces of Law and oppose the machinations of Chaos. Their exploits become legendary, as they wander the world, destroying eldritch altars and restoring saintly shrines, to make the world a safer place.

In any case...

...the Archbishop of Radiant Vitela uses the tragic and horrific tales of the Obsidian Keep to keep the small folk faithful and subservient...







Appendix 1

Memento

Places

✿ **SAKEEN SEA.** A large sea ringed by many wealthy and powerful ports or city-states that regularly engage in trade and warfare with each other - *Can be replaced with any similar sea.*

✿ **RADIANT VITELA.** A large prosperous city and seaport, with numerous religious and political factions - *Can be replaced with any bustling, cosmopolitan port city.*

✿ **ISLA REQUIA.** A little island, one day's sail from the coast, near Radiant Vitela. Primarily rocky, hilly, and grassy. Has one natural harbor, otherwise surrounded by cliffs. Fishing, sheep, and goats support a sparse population of serfs and servants who live in and around the Obsidian Keep.

✿ **OBSDIAN KEEP.** A black stone palace on Isla Requia, known for its small cadre of decadent nobles and habit of attacking nearby ships using small vessels and dark sorcery.

People

✿ **ARCHBISHOP.** A powerful zealot of Law who believes that a righteous end justifies any means. He sought to destroy the decadent nobles at the Obsidian Keep, but needed to generate religious outrage to justify the expense. Therefore, he sent the Chaotic Cult of Vermesh to Duke Avito, hoping to corrupt the people of the Obsidian Keep so deeply that the Lawful people of Radiant Vitela would go to war against the Keep. And they did. But they arrived one day too late - *Can be replaced with a similarly extremist religious or political leader.*

✿ **DUKE AVITO.** A merchant prince, once respected for his keen business mind and success in shipping. Since marrying the sorceress Forza, he became obsessed with arcane powers and sought to obtain such abilities through any means. When the red priests of Vermesh arrived, he was easily

seduced by promises of eldritch power without needing to actually study or understand that power.

✿ **DUCHESS FORZA.** A keen scholar, master politician, and powerful magician. She married Duke Avito for his wealth, to support her arcane research and projects. She used her powers to protect the Keep and Isla Requia, and loved her children. She tolerated the red priests of Vermesh because it kept her husband distracted, but she failed to realize how dangerous they truly were.

✿ **ORSINO, VIOLA, AND BIANCA.** The Duke and Duchess's children.

✿ **VERMESH.** A true eldritch horror that was once banished from reality, and now wishes to return. Its true form is a gigantic red worm with randomly arranged (and shifting) golden eyes, and a circular mouth with golden shark-like teeth. It has grown weak during its time in limbo, and now wishes to feed to regain its former strength. Cares nothing for humanity, and barely acknowledges its worshippers as minor appendages of its own will and body.

✿ **THE RED PRIESTS OF VERMESH.** They are few, and shunned. During initiation, the horror Vermesh devours the priest's eyes and left arm to bestow upon them spirit-sight and a spirit-limb. The mere presence of the cult radiates Chaos, confusion, and mutations into the innocent (or not-so-innocent) people nearby. Their current goal is to complete the year-long ritual that will summon Vermesh into the mundane world. While under the protection of Duke Avito at the Obsidian Keep, they were recently able to complete this ritual.





Appendix 2

New Magic Items

✦ **ADMIRAL'S CUTLASS** - This magic weapon (as short sword +1) has an ornate golden hilt with white coral spikes. The bearer can cast *remove fear* / *cause fear* (1/day).

✦ **ANGELFIRE GRENADE** - Apple-sized silver sphere. Twist to arm, three seconds to boom (2d6). Can ignite or shatter nearby materials.

✦ **ARCANE EYE** - Cloudy, swirling. The magically preserved eye of the magician Prospero, which contains a sliver of his mind and soul (possessed). ▶ Touch the eye to an object or creature and Prospero's voice booms from nowhere, identifying or explaining it with dripping sarcasm and obvious prejudice (1/day).

✦ **BIANCA'S CIRCLET** - When placed in its case in Bianca's room (p. 62), it summons a sylph (Tiny pink six-winged moth-man, bard caste, intelligent but does not speak), which entertains whoever last touched Bianca's circlet (soothing music and lights.) for 1d6 hours 1/day. **If worn:** Gain +1 CHA. Disables the trap at the door of Bianca's room.

✦ **BLACK LEATHER JACKET** - Striking. Sexy. Cool. All of the wearer's reaction rolls are coin tosses (heads = total success and tails = horrific failure).

✦ **BLACK PEARLS (EARRINGS)** - The creatures wearing these paired pearls can exchange telepathic messages, up to 500 feet (3/day).

✦ **BLUE EGGS** - Break an egg on a creature to create a lifeless clone of that creature.

✦ **CHAOS IDOL OF VERMESH** - *Abstract, hideous.* Lawful creatures cannot cast spells or heal in the chapel. ▶ **Cursed:** Idol bearer must save vs death each day or mutate into a **ravenous wyrmiling** (p. 37). Effect can only be ended by a 24-hour vigil with a Lawful priest.

✦ **CRIMSON CATGUT** - The wearer is immune to disease, deafness, and blindness.

✦ **CRYSTAL KNIFE** - This ancient magic blade is a tooth stolen from one of the five seraphim, the engines of creation. It can pierce anything in the universe, but only does 1d4 damage.

✦ **EYE OF RAHAVIL** - *Not really an angel eye.* Bearer is immune to drowning. They still lose consciousness for 2d6 turns.

✦ **FORZA'S CROWN** - Solid gold set with black pearls and sapphires. Doubles the range, duration, or power of any spell (1/day).

✦ **FORZA'S STAFF** - Made of the bones of dead magicians, including the skull of the mad wizard Prospero, who offers unhelpful comments. The bearer is immune to lightning, can summon storm clouds, and can cast *azure lightning* (d6 to five targets or 5d6 to one target, 1/day).

✦ **HAMZA'S GLOVES** - The wearer of these magic leather gloves can safely touch any object (hot, cold, magical, acid, lava, fire, etc.).

✦ **HOLY STAFF OF VITELA** - This emerald-studded golden staff was once carried by the archbishops of radiant vitela. The bearer takes half damage from Chaotic magic. Touch the staff to a Chaotic creature to banish it from this plane of existence (1/day).

✦ **MARINER'S LANTERN** - The dim red glow from this magic lantern offers little light, but it clears away fog for 100 feet in all directions.

✦ **MASK OF SELACHI** - Enchanted. Wearer's bones turn to soft cartilage, can easily squeeze through narrow gaps. -4 to melee attacks and other Str based rolls.

✦ **NECHROME WEAPONS** - Two daggers, one Nechrome rapier, one two-handed sword, one nechrome spear, ten nechrome arrows. Cause freezing wounds (1 per round until warmed), freeze mundane water on contact up to 10'x10'x10' (1/day - the weapon stops freezing wounds until dawn).

✦ **OFFICER BADGE** - Immune to fear. Command up to 10 humans within 120' to stop, flee, or be silent for 1 turn (1/day).

✦ **ORSINO'S CIRCLET** - When placed in its case in Prince Orsino's room (p. 60): It summons a sylph (tiny gray six-winged moth-man, intelligent but does not speak) cleric, which heals whoever last touched Orsino's circlet (d6 hp, cures poison and ends diseases, once per day). **If worn:** Gain +1 WIS. Disables the trap at the door of Bianca's room (p. 62).

✦ **POXMASTER MASK** - Wearer is immune to disease and mutation, and other inhaled effects.

✦ **RED ORCHID DUST** - inhale and giggle uncontrollably for 2d6 turns. Anyone who hears the giggle must save vs paralysis or begin giggling until you stop. Speech and spellcasting are impossible.

✦ **SAPPHIRE RING** - Seagull form. Anyone who puts on the ring turns into a seagull until the ring is removed. When the ring is removed from the current seagull, it reverts to an elderly woman named Gertrid who has no memory of anything useful, but knows many bread recipes.

✦ **SILVER BOOK OF HANNUVIEL** - Legendary tales of Lawful saints and heroes. Contains the only written record of the road to Carrion Vale and the last known location of the Golden Skull of Saint Anarak (legendary relic). Book bearer is immune to charms and can detect lies for 1 turn (1/week).

✦ **SILVO'S ARMOR** - This hulking black plate armor is immune to fire and lightning damage.

✦ **SILVO'S CLEAVER** - This ugly weapon of patched steel has a vicious serrated edge that deals 1d8+2 damage. On an attack roll of 1, the cleaver shatters, damaging the wielder instead.

✦ **SILVO'S CHAIN** - This rusty chain whip ends in an iron weight covered in razor blades. 10-foot reach, 2d4+2 damage. On an attack roll of 1, the chain wraps around the wielder and fuses solid: arm useless, user encumbered; chain must be destroyed.

✦ **SOULSTONE** - Bearer has 18 Intelligence, 4-in-6 chance to identify any natural creature or phenomenon on sight, or to know one fact about any historical event. They also become phobic of chaos.

✦ **VAMPIRE'S DRESS** - Woven of cosmoth silk, grants immunity to light-based dangers (sunlight, radiant beams, etc.).

✦ **VIOLA'S CIRCLET** - When placed in its case in Princess Viola's room (p. 62), it summons a sylph (tiny brown six winged warrior, intelligent but does not speak), which protects whoever last touched Viola's circlet from tiny creatures (insects, rats, etc.) for 1d6 hours 1/day. **If worn:** Gain +1 DEX. Disables the trap at the door of Bianca's room.





Appendix 3

Potential Retainers or replacement characters

Most of them are at the roaring bonfire (p. 24). Roll on page 43 of *KNOCK!* #3 so each character has one piece of interesting equipment

Little Yon - Young ship's boy, forcibly enrolled by the attacking fleet. Wants to go home and kill the recruiting sergeant (Chief Drollo).

1st level Thief

STR 8, INT 13, WIS 9, DEX 16, CON 10, CHA 12
HP 3, AL N

› **Equipment:** Short saber, sling, iron bullets (12), candles (4), thieves' tools, steel wire (9'), 7 GP.

Kulisto - Former cook on the *Shining Lady*, woke up on the beach after the shipwreck. Has been trying to rebuild a proper kitchen ever since.

1st level Halfling

STR 10, INT 9, WIS 8, DEX 12, CON 17, CHA 11
HP 8, AL N

› **Equipment:** Leather armor, butcher knife, flint and steel, lantern, oil (6 flasks), rations (6), recipe book, 13 GP.

Chief Drollo - Recruiting sergeant and petty officer on the *Shining Lady*. Wishes to return to his former life.

1st level Fighter

STR 16, INT 7, WIS 10, DEX 9, CON 13, CHA 14
HP 6, AL L

› **Equipment:** Chainmail, saber, handaxe, whip, lantern, oil (3 flasks), flint and steel, 22 GP.

Obsidia - The black suit of armor of one of Duke Avito's ancestors, formerly on display in the keep's council chamber. Sentient and animated since the red storm, it wanders, wondering about its newly given life...

1st level Living Harness (See *KNOCK!* 1)

STR 14, INT 10, WIS 6, DEX 10, CON 14, CHA 10
HP 8, AL N

› **Equipment:** Armor repair kit, broadsword, crossbow (10 quarrels), matches (20), grappling hook, silver mirror, flint and steel, 12 GP.

Gladadius - Distracted, always suffering from a cold. Former meteorologist aboard the *Golden Dove*. Dislikes danger and adventure.

1st level Magic-user

STR 7, INT 16, WIS 12, DEX 12, CON 8, CHA 9
HP 1, AL N

› **Equipment:** dagger, darts (6), torches (6), matches (20), scissors, incense sticks (12), spellbook (*charm person, floating disc, read languages*), candles (4), sewing kit, 13 GP.

Niponia - Zealous fanatic in the service of the Archbishop. Likes to launch into grandiloquent speeches... despite her stammer.

1st level Inquisitor (See *KNOCK!* 4)

STR 16, INT 9, WIS 14, DEX 8, CON 11, CHA 9
HP 4, AL L

› **Equipment:** chainmail, shield, crossbow (40 quarrels), hammer, flint and steel, lantern, oil (6 flasks), holy symbol, 17 GP.

Nolbur - Cheerful, enthusiastic, full of positive energy but half-crazy. Formerly in charge of catapults on the *Hammer of Faith*. Luxurious, fiery red beard.

1st level Dwarf

STR 16, INT 8, WIS 7, DEX 9, CON 16, CHA 12
HP 7, AL C

› **Equipment:** Leather armor, short bow, arrows (40), short sword, shield, tinder box, hunting horn, torches (6), garlic, grappling hook, 19 GP.

Raëndil - Fussy, extremely polite, rather irritating. Accompanied the fleet as an observer and diplomat from the Elven Kingdoms.

1st level Elf

STR 9, INT 11, WIS 10, DEX 14, CON 9, CHA 14
HP 4, AL L

› **Equipment:** Chainmail, hand axe, long bow (20 arrows), torches (6), rations (7), 10-foot pole, spellbook (*magic missile, light, ventriloquism*), matchbox, torches (6), 24 GP.



Snortik - Emaciated, gray-skinned, feverish-looking. Former castle exterminator. Hates the open air and sunlight. Good company.

1st level Rat Catcher (See **KNOCK! 3**)

STR 10, INT 8, WIS 14, DEX 16, CON 9, CHA 7 HP 4, AL N

► **Equipment:** Leather armor, scimitar, sling (20 bullets), iron spikes (12), lantern (with 2 oil flasks), rations (7), rope (50'), tinder box, scroll case, 12 GP.

Radamant the Green Knight - Pompous, reckless, hyperactive. All his equipment is painted in emerald green. Knight-errant wannabe.

1st level Fighter

STR 16, INT 8, WIS 9, DEX 9, CON 12, CHA 12 HP 7, AL L

► **Equipment:** Chainmail, shield, broadsword, lance, torches (6), flint and steel, holy water (1 vial).

Xiux - A scientist taken as a slave by space vampiress Pavnutia (currently in the *Black pit* p. 43) and freed when her teleportation spell to Earth was miscast. They look for a way home, posing as a halfling with a weird accent.

1st level Grey (See **KNOCK! 2**)

STR 11, INT 12, WIS 8, DEX 11, CON 15, CHA 9 HP 3, AL L

► **Equipment:** Silver armor (as chainmail), quarterstaff, sling (12 silver bullets), phaser, shield generator, rations (2), collection of plants and insects, curly wig with moustache, 12 GP.

Hortensio - A local fisherman, who went out to feed his brother Gotran's family (hiding in the *Driftwood shack* p. 20). Gotran was torn apart by vulgranes in the first hour of search. Hortensio decided to run and hide. Wrecked by hunger and guilt, wearing stolen arms and armor.

1st level Fighter

STR 13, INT 17, WIS 4, DEX 11, CON 9, CHA 12 HP 8, AL N

► **Equipment:** Chainmail, two-handed sword, long bow (13 arrows), torches (3), holy symbol (platinum, worth 200 GP).

Anonymous Professor Number

Thirteen - Sent by the Invisible College of the Unnamed Magi, her expedition was captured by the Vitelan fleet and put to death for heresy. Thirteen only escaped by turning invisible and hiding in the bilge water. Raven haired, imperious, and a master fencer. Seeks magical knowledge to avoid losing her tenure on her return.

1st level Magic-user

STR 13, INT 14, WIS 11, DEX 10, CON 6, CHA 13 HP 3, AL N

► **Equipment:** Red professorial robes and cap, long sword, two daggers, spell book (*detect magic*, *hold portal*, *shield*), potion of invisibility (enough left for one body part or a small animal), field books, pen and ink, 32 GP.

Sister Solemnity of the Crimson

Thunder - A warrior-priestess from an allied cult, Solemnity was part of the invading fleet. She saw the red storm as a sign not to get involved with this conflict anymore. Much more cheerful than her name suggests.

1st level Cleric

STR 12, INT 12, WIS 14, DEX 10, CON 10, CHA 5 HP 5, AL L

► **Equipment:** Platemail, shield, mace, sling (20 white stones), holy symbol, red and purple vestments, censer-lantern (2 flasks of oil), prayer cake (3 rations), holy scripture scrolls, 7 SP.

Bolivor - The Brute, as he was called in his thieving days, really tried to go on the straight and narrow as a fisherman. But the circumstances decided otherwise. Ah well, what's a little blood on an honest man's hands?

1st level Thief

STR 14, INT 9, WIS 11, DEX 12, CON 5, CHA 10 HP 2, AL N

► **Equipment:** Leather armor, battle axe, crossbow (9 quarrels), dagger, thieves' tools, holy water (2 flasks), silver mirror, torches (6), 3 GP.

This character sheet belongs to::

Name

Alignment

Class/Level

XP

STR:

INT:

WIS:

DEX:

CON:

CHA:

Saving Throws

D Death,
Poison

W Magic
wands

P Paralysis,
Petrification

B Breath
attacks

S Spells, magic
rods & staves

Health

HD:

+/- CON mod.:

HP:

Max:

Armor Class

Armor:

Shield:

+/- Dex:

AC: [] Unarmored: [] Mv:

Encounters

+/- CHA mod. to reaction rolls:

+/- DEX mod. to Initiative:

+/- STR mod. to melee att./damage:

+/- DEX mod. to ranged attacks:

THAC0: []

EQUIPMENT

CP:

SP:

GP:

EP:

PP:

Gems:

SKILLS, SPELLS & ABILITIES

☐ I survived to the Obsidian Keep!

☐ I died in the Obsidian Keep!